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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Lalita Niwas land scam

Special Court convicts 12, including Dhakal, Subedi and Gurung

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Feb. 15



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Special Court officials making public the verdict of Lalita Niwas land scam at a press conference organised in Kathmandu on Thursday.

*** Former DPM Gachchhadhar, two ex-ministers acquitted**
*** 65 individuals' Baluwatar land to be confiscated**
*** Min Bahadur, Shobhakant, Deep Basnyat sentenced to 2-yr imprisonment**
*** 136 ropanis of land to be brought under govt registration**

The Special Court has given its verdict on the much-talked-about Lalita Niwas land scam convicting 12 high-profile individuals as guilty.

However, the court acquitted former deputy prime minister Bijaya Kumar Gachchhadar and two former ministers Chandra Dev Joshi and Dambar Shrestha. The verdict was announced by the bench comprising Special Court judges Khushi Prasad Tharu, Ram Bahadur Thapa and Ritendra Thapa on Thursday.

Making the verdict public by organising a press conference on the premises of Special Court this afternoon, Deputy Registrar and Spokesperson for the Court Dhana Bahadur Karki said that three former ministers, including former Deputy Prime Minister Bijaya Kumar Gachchhadhar were acquitted in the case related to the grabbing of the government land at Lalita Niwas, in Baluwatar.

The final verdict was announced after continuous hearings spanning from January 16 to February 13 with 175 defendants, including prominent figures like former Deputy Prime Minister Gachchhadhar, Bhatbhateni Supermarket's owner Min Bahadur Gurung and former ministers Chandra Dev Joshi and Dambar Shrestha.

Among the accused, 110 individuals have already been sentenced while the Thursday's verdict ordered to confiscate land purchased by 65 individuals.

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) filed the case in the Special Court on February 5, 2020. The CIAA alleged corruption involving the misappropriation of over 136 ropanis of government land at Lalita Niwas in Baluwatar.

The main defendants in the charge sheet, including Ram Kumar Subedi, Sobhakanta Dhakal and Min Bahadur Gurung, were identified as the masterminds and middlemen behind the land scam. Former Prime Ministers Madhav Kumar Nepal and Dr. Baburam Bhattarai provided statements in the case, but the CIAA declined to prosecute, citing a lack of jurisdiction.

However, a writ against this has been pending in the Supreme Court.

Furthermore, revelations about the transfer of government land in the names of sitting Supreme Court Justice Kumar Regmi and UML Vice Chairman Bishnu Paudel's son added complexities to the case.

Similarly, the Special Court convicted the former chief commissioner of the Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) Deep Basnyat, former secretary Chhabiraj Panta and others in the same land corruption case.

Former Secretary Panta, Basnyat and others have been found to have committed corruption by arranging fake mohi (tillers) under the cover of the decision of the Council of Ministers and exchanged 19 ropanis of the land in their names. Each of them were sentenced to two-year imprisonment and fined Rs. 8 million.

Further, Bhatbhateni's owner Gurung, Ram Kumar Subedi and Shobhakant Dhakal were also convicted guilty of corruption and sentenced to two-year imprisonment and a fine of Rs. 8 million each.

The Special Court in its verdict said that the Lalita Niwa's land which had been transferred to 65 individuals,

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PM stresses initiatives to retain youths, resources within Nepal



BY KEDAR TIMSINA
Banepa, Feb. 15

The North Zone Vice Chancellors' Meet and Bharat-Nepal Higher Education Summit kicked off at Kathmandu University in Dhulikhel on Thursday.

Inaugurating the event, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said that brain drain from the country should be stopped. He said that initiatives should be taken to retain youths and the resources associated with them within the country.

The Prime Minister stressed the need to reevaluate internationalisation of higher education. Stating that the educational sector had to struggle with the challenges introduced by the global powers, he said that students and scholars were attracted to universities in the North due to the availability of resources for higher education and skills.

He said, "Educational balance has shifted towards the North globally. Although the education system in the North had attracted students because of its expensive budget, this may not sustain for long."

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the South's original intellectual assets had contributed to the fields of medical education, lifestyle and peace-building. Stating that the South-North division based on economic criteria should be reduced, he pointed to the need to find common ground to unite the two regions.

He said that Kathmandu University (KU) has taken initiative to draft a declaration to connect the North and South and such an intellectual initiative would help the whole world. He expressed happiness over KU's continuous effort on internationalisation and expansion of educational activities during its 32 years of history, graduating more than 5,000 international students.

He said that the KU's initiatives had not only focused on educational proposals in Nepal but also promoted mutual cultural understanding and cooperation.

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It might take additional 32 years to achieve SDGs: ESCAP

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Progress on the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) remains uneven and inadequate across various segments of the population and within the five subregions of Asia and the Pacific. According to a new report published by the Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP) on Thursday, gender and location remain key factors in determining levels of poverty and inequality in the region.

The report noted that at its current pace, the region will not achieve all 17 SDGs before 2062 – marking a significant 32-year delay. While positive steps have been taken toward eliminating poverty (Goal 1) and bolstering sustainable industry, innovation and infrastructure (Goal 9) in the region, progress in other critical areas has been more modest. Efforts towards mitigating hunger (Goal 2), enhancing health and well-being (Goal 3), ensuring the availability of clean water and sanitation (Goal 6), expanding affordable and clean energy (Goal 7) and building sustainable cities and communities (Goal 11) have been less pronounced and require heightened attention.

According to the report, Nepal's progress up to now is below the target in most of the goals. Nepal has seen some progress in areas such as sustainable urban expansion and spatial data generation. However, there are areas where Nepal is experiencing slow progress and regression, particularly in achieving food security and combating undernourishment (Goal 2) and reducing inequalities within and among countries (Goal 10).

The report underscores the importance of addressing these challenges and customising strategies to address specific issues in Nepal. Despite improvements in data collection, significant data gaps still exist, concludes the report.

Gender equality (Goal 5) and peace, justice and strong institutions (Goal 16) continue to have the least available data. This report assesses Nepal's SDG progress at the global level indicators; and we should be careful interpreting this report in relation to the SDG Report of the Government of Nepal that uses nationalized indicators to assess the SDG progress.

The Asia and the Pacific SDG Progress Report 2024 takes a closer look at groups that may be disadvantaged, focusing on how sex, urbanisation, education level, age and income contribute to existing disparities and sometimes exacerbate them.

Despite overall progress in school

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Maoist Centre's statute convention concludes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Prime Minister and Chairman of the CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said that the first statute convention concluded in a civilised manner and it would support in the party's formation and the upcoming general convention.

After receiving suggestions from the party members on the last day of the statute convention on Thursday, the Prime Minister said that the party would be strengthened based on the received suggestions.

He said conclusions were reached to form new committee through a direct election system after the upcoming session and to elect individuals to different positions of state affairs through direct election from the committee.

Stating that majority of participants suggested reducing the size of the party committee, Prime Minister Prachanda said that a 199-member central committee would be formed after the next convention. Additionally, a central office consisting of 11 members would be established and made effective after the next convention.

He said that it would be appropriate to work ahead by formulating regulations to fix the qualification and term of office. Stating that the statute would highly prioritise strengthening provinces, he said that it would enhance the effectiveness of federalism and proportional system.

He said that decisions on changing the party's name and election symbol would be done at an appropriate time. He said the name of the party could be changed in a situation where many communist parties would be united else it would remain as it is.

He said that the fronts would be given autonomy with ideological training and the people's organisation would also be expanded.

10 die in Kapilvastu bus accident

BY NARAD KOHAR
Kapilvastu, Feb. 15

At least 10 passengers died and 30 others sustained injuries in a bus accident in the Surahi River at Shivaraj Municipality-1 of Kapilvastu district Thursday morning.

The passenger bus (Su-Pa-Pra-02-001 Kha 0098), belonging to Mahakali Transport, fell almost 200 metres down into the river from the highway at around 12:15 on Thursday morning. The bus was heading to Kathmandu from Mahendranagar. All the 10 deceased have been identified.

According to Deputy Superintendent of Police Hari Oli of the District Police Office, the deceased have been identified as 46-year-old Narayan Bahadur Bhandari of Aurahi-3, Rautahat, Arjun Kumar Yogi, 55-year-old Sakil Muslim of Moradabad, Uttar Pradesh, India, 27-year-old Rahul Ram Kami of Bhimdutta Municipality-1 Kanchanpur, 24-year-old Umesh Bhandari of Bhimdutta-4, and 27-year-old Sanju Thapa of Bhimdutta Municipality-16.

Similarly, 21-year-old Khageshwari Khati of Bhimdutta Municipality, Sudeep Bhatta of Bhimdutta Municipality-2, Bimala Devi Bhatta of Punarwas Municipality-9 and Bisan Dutta Bhatta of Punarwas Municipality-9 were killed in the accident.

Of the injured, nine are receiving treatment at Chandrauta Hospital in Butwal. Kapilvastu's Superintendent of Police Navaratna Paudel said that others are receiving treatment at Sanjivani and Basic Hospital, Chandrauta.

Police Superintendent Paudel said that the accident occurred due to brake failure. In the accident, constable Lok Bahadur, bus driver N.P. Purna Bahadur Chand, Mahesh Sunar, Shushil Kunwar, Arjun Karki, Rajesh Dayal and Nitesh Sunar among others were injured.

NOTICE

There is no *Friday Supplement* in today's issue of the The Rising Nepal.

–Editor

Milky way project brings smiles in Sindhuli farmers

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Sindhulimadhi, Feb. 15



With the first purebred Holstein calf last week, Kamalamai Municipality in Sindhuli district has inched a step forward in developing itself as a model dairy village and national nucleus for the new methods of cow rearing.

The cow kept by Guna Kumari Ghimire, a member of Gaiya Devi Women Entrepreneurs Self-help Group in Kamalamai-5, Gaiyatar, gave the first purebred calf of the Korean-breed Holstein for the first time in the country. It was possible with the collaboration among the municipality, Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development (MoALD), Heifer International in Nepal and Korea, Sindhuli Integrated Development Services (SIDS), and local communities.

Ghimire handed over the newly-born calf to Uma Subedi, a young woman who is also a member of the Group, at a programme organised in her shed in the presence of Livestock Secretary of the MoALD, Dr. Rewati Raman Poudel, South Korea's Ambassador to Nepal, Park Tae-Young, Mayor of Kamalamai Upendra Kumar Pokharel and officials of the Department of Livestock and other agencies.

However, the calf will remain with its mother for the next seven months before formally leaving for a new shed.

"I have taken this moment as an opportunity. I am very excited now as I was while welcoming the new Korean cow into my newly built shed a year earlier," said Ghimire.

In response, Subedi said that she too was excited. "I feel lucky to get it. I think it will open more economic opportunity for us," she said.

As per the project rules, the farmers, who received the new breed of Korean cow in a grant and financial support to upgrade sheds, should give away the first calf to another member of their community. This practice will make sure that a significant number of farmers here will have a Holstein cow within the next few years.

Under the Milky Way Project, the stakeholders collaborated to bring 100 Holstein cows that will produce 10,000 litres of milk over each milking period and eight high-fertility bulls from South Korea last year.

Of these cows, 80 were distributed to 50 farmer families in two communities in Kamalamai. The remaining cows and bulls were sent to National Livestock Birthing Office in Pokhara and Lahan, Cattle Genetic Resource Centre in Jiri, National Livestock Birthing and Genetic Reserch Centre in Lalitpur and National Cow Research Programme in Chitwan.

The project aims to develop a model dairy village in Kamalamai and to demonstrate the modern methods of cow rearing to other farmers' communities.

The cow kept by Ghimire is producing 28-30 litres of milk in a day which is expected to increase up to 40 litres in a day within a month or two. "This is something that we never expected. Local cows produce only 2-3 litres of milk in a day while a cross of Jersey cow produces 10 litres a day," said Bhola Adhikari, a local.

The cow needs about 5 kg of feed, 15 kg of green grass and 7 kg of dry grass in a day. According to farmers they have spent about Rs. 175,000 in the past 13 months to rear a cow. However, the cost could be recovered in the next four or five months.

Mayor Pokharel said that the milk production in the municipality next

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Supervision consultant selected for 1,063 MW Upper Arun

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15



PHOTO: TRN

Promoter of the Upper Arun Hydro-Electric Limited and the consultant at tender design, preparation of bidding document, construction supervision and post-construction services' agreement programme on Thursday.

A supervision consultant has been selected for the 1,063 MW Upper Arun semi-reservoir hydropower project to be built in Bhotkhola Rural Municipality of Sankhuwasabha district.

The contract agreement has been signed for the consulting service-- tender design, preparation of bidding document, construction supervision and post-construction services for the Upper Arun Hydroelectric Project with the Joint Venture of Tractebel Engineering GmbH, Germany (Lead firm), Tracteble Engineering S.A., France and WAPCOS Limited, India.

The Upper Arun Hydropower Project, declared as a game changer project by the government, is being implemented by the Upper Arun Hydroelectric Limited (UAHEL), a subsidiary Company of Nepal Electricity Authority.

The contract agreement was signed between the promoter of the project Upper Arun Hydro-Electric Limited and the consultant on Wednesday, according to the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA).

The contract cost for construction supervision consulting services is 23.4 million Euros and Rs. 643 million, including VAT and the provisional sum is USD 445,000.

Arrangements have been made to pay the consultancy services in three separate currencies-- Euro, Dollar and rupees.

The duration of the consultancy service is 117 months.

According to the contract agreement, the consultant will prepare the design and tender-related documents under the first phase of 21 months.

In the 72-month second phase, the construction work of the project will be supervised.

In the 24-month third phase, consulting services for project management and maintenance will be provided, according to the agreement.

During the agreement signing ceremony, NEA Managing Director and Chairman of the Board of Directors of the Upper Arun Hydroelectric Limited Kul Man Ghising said that an important step had been completed as a consultant has been appointed to supervise the construction of the game-changer project.

Stating that it is a very important task to prepare the tender documents to select the contractor for the construction of the main structure of the project within nine months, Ghising requested to complete the work in time by taking care of every second.

"We are trying to advance the project as a model project of 'mixed investment' involving the Nepal government, provincial government, local levels of project-affected districts and the residents, common people from all over the country, concessional loans from international multilateral development partners and loans from local banks and financial institutions," he said.

Under the leadership of the World Bank, the process of financial management by international financial institutions will be done by June, he said.

"Pre-construction preparations are underway at the project site, and the necessary works are being done to arrange the financial arrangements and take it to the construction phase as soon as possible, " he said.

According to the managing director of Upper Arun Hydroelectric Limited Phadindra Raj Joshi, preparations are being made to sign an investment framework agreement ranging from USD 1 billion to USD 1.20 billion by the international financial institutions led by the World Bank at the investment conference slated for April.

At the base price of 2019, the estimated cost of the project is USD 1.75 billion (approximately Rs. 214 billion), including the interest of the construction period and inflation. Of the total cost, 70 per cent will be raised from loan and 30 per cent from equity.

In the co-financing led by the World Bank, a plan has been made to arrange the financial management by raising funds from international financial institutions and the local banks and financial institutions.

Under the leadership of Hydroelectricity Investment and Development Company (HIDCL), a memorandum of understanding has already been signed to raise about Rs. 53 billion through co-financing from the local banks and financial institutions.

Fifty-one per cent of the equity will be collected from the promoter shares of Upper Arun Hydroelectric Company, the promoter of the project, and 49 per cent from public shares.

Project-affected residents and general people across the country will have 49 per cent general shares. Pre-construction works are underway to start construction from the beginning of 2026. The construction of the project is targeted to be completed by 2031.

Among the preparations for the project, the construction of about 21 kilometers of access roads, including 2 kilometres of tunnels has started. Office buildings and residences are being constructed at the project site.

The acquisition of 232.14 hectares of private land required for the project has been completed and distribution of 90 per cent compensation has been completed, said the NEA.

The project has been designed to run at full capacity for 6 hours a day during the 6 months of winter when electricity demand is high.

According to the NEA, the project will produce 4.53 billion units of electricity annually. About 30 per cent of the total electricity generation will be produced in winter.

The generated electricity will be supplied to the national grid through the proposed substation at Haitar in Sankhuwasabha.

CONTRACTORS PRESS FOR PAYMENT

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum West, Feb. 14

A construction company responsible for blacktopping of the road in Radi Bazaar, the centre of Aathbiskot Municipality in Rukum West, warned of halting the work after the payment was delayed for almost five months.

Stating that the company had not received payment for the past five months, Gorkha Mangaldeep JV which has already completed 80 per cent of blacktopping work in Radi Bazaar, Campus Road and Pasane Road of Ward No. 8 stated that they would leave the work unfinished if they did not receive the payment within 15 days.

Raj Shahi, director of the construction company, said that they faced many problems and could not pay 15 employees and 50 workers mobilised in the construction work due to delayed payment.

The construction of the road was awarded to the Gorkha Mangaldeep JV last April for Rs. 207.9 million and the construction company had committed to complete the project by August 30, 2024. To date, the company has only received Rs. 60 million.

Surya Shahi, a site in-charge of the company, said that only four kilometres of the road remained to get blacktopped. "Preparations for the remaining work have been completed. However, many workers have faced difficulties with their daily expenditures due to delays in the payment. We have already submitted a bill amounting to Rs. 50 million based on the work progress at the concerned department," said Sahi.

Ram Krishna Acharya, head of the Federal Level Project Implementation Unit, said that they had demanded payment at the federal level after receiving the bill from the construction company. He said that payments would be made soon since 80 per cent of the work was already completed.

He informed that the company had already finished the work of drainage, gravel and concreting the road in the remaining four kilometres of the road. Along with the blacktopping of the main road in the Aathbiskot area, a bus park is also being constructed there.

German chancellor welcomes Microsoft's $3.5 billion AI investment in Germany



PHOTO: AP

Federal Chancellor Olaf Scholz, right, and Vice Chair and President of Microsoft Corporation Brad Smith shake hands in Berlin, `Thursday, Feb. 15, 2024.

AP
Berlin, Feb. 15

German Chancellor Olaf Scholz welcomed an announcement Thursday by Microsoft that it would invest almost 3.3 billion euros ($3.5 billion) in Germany over the next two years to massively expand its data center capacities for applications in the field of artificial intelligence and cloud computing.

"This is a really good commitment to progress, to growth, to modernity and to global openness as the basis for these opportunities," he said, adding it was also linked to the "fact that Germany remains very determined to be an open economy."

"Not only are we probably the most successful export economy in the world in terms of the size of our country, but we are also a country that trades with the whole world, that invests everywhere, but also invests in our own country," he said.

Microsoft President Brad Smith made the announcement in Berlin during a presentation with Scholz.

The largest single investment in Microsoft's 40-year history in Germany also includes an AI training program that aims to reach up to 1.2 million people, German news agency dpa reported.

Microsoft is looking to be close to major customers, such as the pharmaceutical company Bayer AG and energy company RWE, in order to keep data latency between data centers and applications as low as possible.

The central German state of Hesse will also benefit from Microsoft's investments.

US ANNOUNCES $970 MILLION IN GRANTS FOR AIRPORT IMPROVEMENTS

AP
Washington, Feb. 15

The Biden administration said Thursday it is providing $970 million for improvements at 114 airports around the country, with work ranging from wider concourses and new baggage-handling systems to new terminals at some small airfields. Administration officials said the money comes from a $5 billion grant program to modernize airport terminals.

The largest sum, $50 million, will go to Fort Lauderdale-Hollywood International Airport in Florida for a project to connect terminals behind the security checkpoints and provide new retail space and other amenities.

O'Hare International Airport in Chicago will get $40 million to widen a concourse, reconfigure a security checkpoint and other changes. Phoenix Sky Harbor International Airport, Washington Dulles International Airport in northern Virginia, San Francisco International and Los Angeles International will receive amounts ranging from $31 million to $36 million.

A Federal Aviation Administration official said there were more than 600 applications and requests totaled $14 billion.

Gold price falls to Rs. 116,500 per tola



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Gold price has significantly decreased in the local market. The price of gold has dropped by Rs. 2,000 per tola in the domestic market in the five transaction days this week.

According to the Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association (FENEGOSIDA), the price of gold decreased to Rs. 116,500 per tola (11.664 grams) on Thursday compared to Rs. 118,500 on Friday last week.

The price of gold decreased sharply on a single day on Wednesday due to a decrease in its price in the international market, said Tej Ratna Shakya, a gold trader and special member of the FENEGOSIDA.

The price of gold declined by Rs. 1,200 per tola to Rs. 116,500 on Wednesday as compared to Tuesday's price. Gold was traded at Rs. 117,700 per tola on Tuesday in the local market.

However, the price of gold remained unchanged on Thursday.

The gold price in the domestic market had reached all-time high at Rs. 122,000 per tola on December 28, 2023. According to Shakya, with the rise in the exchange rate of the US dollar, investors have been attracted to the dollar by selling gold, which led to the fall in gold price.

Fluctuations in the international market price have an impact on the domestic bullion market as well, he added.

Gold price in the international market has decreased by US$ 41 per ounce to US$ 1,992 on Thursday, he said. The price of gold was USD 2,033 per ounce in the international market on Friday last week. The present scenario showed that the price of gold would further decline in the international market, he said. "But, we cannot predict whether the price of gold will increase or decrease as the price of gold has been fluctuating significantly," he said.

The demand for gold has decreased in the local market even in the wedding season. Shakya said the daily supply of 20 kg gold is enough to meet local demand.

The demand for gold was above 45 kgs daily during the wedding season last year.

EU farmer's frustration grows with every click of mouse

AP
Belgium, Feb. 15

On a farm in northern Belgium, not far from the hundreds of tractors blocking Europe's second-biggest port to demand more respect for farmers, Bart Dochy was switching on his computer, waiting for a government program to load with maps of his land next to empty digital boxes demanding to be filled with statistics on fertilizer, pesticides, production and harvesting.

"They also supervise us with satellite images and even with drones," Dochy said. His frustration highlights the yawning gap in trust and understanding that has opened up between European farmers and what they increasingly see as a nanny state looking into every nook and cranny of their barns, analyzing how every drop of liquid manure is spread.

From Greece to Ireland, from the Baltics to Spain, tens of thousands of farmers and their supporters joined protests across Europe in recent weeks. It was enough to put the farmers' plight on front pages all over the continent, setting it up as a key theme for the June 6-9 parliamentary elections in the 27-nation European Union.

Farmers have always lived by the whim of nature. Fickle regulation, though, they cannot accept. "That is what is creating this level of distrust. It's like living in Russia or China," he said, instead of the fertile flatlands of Flanders in northwestern Belgium.

Farmers have many complaints — from insufficiently regulated cheap imports to overbearing environmental rules — but the reams of red tape set everyone off almost instantly. The EU however, is also the hand that feeds them, with some $50 billion (euros) going into a vast network of programs that touch on agriculture in various ways every year.

In return, farmers must account for their spending — in ways they find increasingly onerous.

At 51, Dochy is far from an embittered, extremist farmer setting bales of hay on fire or spraying manure into government buildings. In his office, as essential as a barn in the life of a current-day EU farmer, hangs the warning "God Watches — No Cursing Here." He comes from old-time farming stock, generations of conservative Christian Democrats that have traditionally provided the backbone of European agriculture.

Once Dochy finishes dealing with 900 pigs and some 30 hectares (74 acres) of corn or potatoes, he exchanges his blue overalls and rubber boots for a three-piece suit. He's also the mayor of this farming community, Ledegem, 120 kilometers (70 miles) west of Brussels where much of the detested EU farm bureaucracy comes from.

Over morning coffee, his father, Frans Dochy, 82, remembers how, in his youth, he would harvest beets out of the cold, thick earth by hand for hours. Yet, he says, 2024 bookkeeping "would have driven me off the farm long ago."

He sees how his son has to register the arrival of any artificial manure within seven days. "And it has to be done even at the busiest times on the field, of course," said Bart Dochy. "Then it has to be registered exactly how it is spread on every single little plot of land — how many kilos and how it is distributed," he explained, going through some of the thick folders in his office.

Nepal Airlines
NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal

Re-Invitation for Sealed Quotation
(International Competitive Bidding)
Date of Publication 15th February 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC), Continuing Airworthiness Management Department Invites Sealed Quotation from PT6A-27 Engine Repair/Overhaul Organization (MROs) for exchange of its two (02) PT6A-27 core engines. The MROs are encouraged to visit the Notice/Announcement page in NAC Website: www.nepalairlines.com.np for detail information and downloading the Sealed Quotation Document.

Completed Sealed Quotation document should reach to the address given below within 07 (Seven) days before 17:00 hours local time from the first date of publication of this notice. For further information, please contact:

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Continuing Airworthiness Management Department,
Tribhuvan International Airport
Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 4113085 / 4113209, Fax: +977 1 4470768
Email: dir.camd@nac.com.np, dydir.epd@nac.com.np
Website: http://www.nepalairlines.com.np *(Notice/Announcement page)*



PHOTO: OFFICE OF THE VICE PRESIDENT

Japan's Ambassador to Nepal Kikuta Yukata paying a courtesy call on Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav at the Office of the Vice President, Lainchaur, on Thursday.

Harassed by rising theft incidents, Waling people picket police office

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling (Syangja), Feb. 15

The town of Waling in Syangja has, of late, seen a significant rise in theft incidents, prompting victims to picket the local police office.

In the past few weeks, incidents of theft have been on the rise in Waling, Syangja. In a single night, both shops in the market and residential houses were broken into stealing cash and goods including scooters and bicycles.

Various areas of the city have witnessed increasing incidents of thefts, leaving the residents anxious. Locals have claimed that even schools and temples have not been spared.

In Waling Municipality-13, particularly in the Jholunge and Thanpata areas, thefts occurred simultaneously in almost a dozen locations, targeting shops, houses and schools.

A scooter belonging to Numkanta Gaire went missing from the main market area of Waling-8. Despite filing a complaint and providing CCTV footage, Gaire alleged that the police had not investigated the matter. He stated, "I went to the police, and they claimed they would search for it, but there is still no information about the whereabouts of the scooter."

In response to the perceived inaction by the police, residents of Waling-13 picketed the Ward Police Office, expressing dissatisfaction over the police's handling of the theft cases.

Hemanta Gaire, a resident, remarked, "We went to the police after being ignored."

The frustrated residents have started conducting their night patrols on their own due to the growing sense of insecurity.

A spate of theft incidents was recorded on Sunday night in the Jholunge market area, where five shops, four houses, and a school were robbed.

According to Ward Chairman of Waling-13, Namlal Dumre, on Sunday night, Rs. 8.5 million cash from the shop of Dilu Ram Gaire, Rs. 30,000 in cash from the shop of Jagga Nath Pathak, five tolas of gold from the house of Ghadi Gurung, a mountain bike cycle from the house of Puran Gurung, liquors of various brands from the shop of Pathak, among others, were stolen from the market areas.

Ward chair Dumre urged the police to intensify efforts in apprehending the culprits and assured support from the community in patrolling the area.

Sanjaya Bahadur Raut, Chief of the District Police Office and Superintendent of Police at the District Police Office, Syangja, also admitted the surge in theft incidents.

He assured the public that the police were taking the matter seriously, instructing all units to perform continuous night duty.

SP Raut emphasised that those involved in theft will be brought to legal action with the support of citizens.

WHO hails Nepal's effort to ban trans-fatty acids in food

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

The World Health Organisation has congratulated Nepal for restricting levels of industrially produced trans-fatty acids in the food supply through legislation.

The WHO has termed the law formulated by Nepal a move aimed at promoting health and saving lives, according to a statement issued by the WHO.

"Eliminating trans-fatty acids is a cost-effective measure with great health benefits in preventing premature deaths from cardiovascular diseases," said Saima Wazed, Regional Director, WHO South-East Asia.

Prioritising prevention and control of noncommunicable diseases (NCDs) in South-East Asia Region, WHO has been supporting countries for the elimination of trans-fatty acids from national food supplies, along with other measures.

With Nepal's legislation, now nearly 80 per cent of the Region's population – 1.6 billion people - will be potentially protected from the harms of trans-fatty acids, read the statement.

Globally, 540,000 deaths every year can be attributed to the intake of industrially produced trans-fatty acids. High trans-fat intake significantly increases the risk of death from cardiovascular diseases. Trans fat has no known health benefits.

In the WHO South-East Asia Region, non-communicable diseases cause 69 per cent of the nearly 9 million deaths every year. Cardiovascular diseases are a major cause of death.

In 2018 WHO released REPLACE a guide of six strategies to help achieve the elimination of industrially produced trans-fatty acids. In collaboration with Resolve to Save Lives, REPLACE protocols are being implemented across the Region.

By 2022, Thailand, India and Bangladesh had adopted regulations for elimination of trans-fatty acids in the food supply. Indonesia had complementary policy measures. Sri Lanka issued a regulation in 2023. Nepal issued the legislation on trans-fatty acids on 8 February.

Restricting trans-fatty acids is one of the measures under WHO South-East Asia Region's 'SEA HEARTS' that emphasises on united effort across all partners and all stakeholders for aligned and effective acceleration of actions to reduce deaths from cardiovascular diseases.

Nepal's legislation on trans-fatty acids will add 30 million people to the SEA HEARTS target of protecting two billion people from the harmful effects of trans-fatty acids through best practice or complementary policy measures of WHO REPLACE by 2025, read the statement.

TRN's former chief editor Lok Deep Thapa felicitated

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Editors' Society Nepal (ESON) has felicitated Lok Deep Thapa, the former Chief Editor of The Rising Nepal.

A team of ESON office bearers, including its senior vice chairman Pushpa Raj Pradhan, general secretary Shyam Dotel and secretary Narayan Upadhyay visited Thapa's home on Thursday and offered him a letter of appreciation for his long contribution to Nepali journalism.

Former Chief Editor Thapa, who also served as general manager of Gorkhapatra Corporation, expressed his happiness for being recognised for his long service as a journalist and shared his experiences with the visiting team.

ESON decided to honour and felicitate Thapa during the death anniversary of its founder chairperson Govinda Biyogi



PHOTO: TRN

Former chief editor of The Rising Nepal, Lok Deep Thapa with senior vice chairman Pushpa Raj Pradhan, general secretary Shyam Dotel and secretary Narayan Upadhyay of Editor's Society Nepal.

As Thapa could not attend the programme held four weeks ago due to his ill health, the ESON team visited Thapa this afternoon to hand over the commendation letter.

LALITPUR INTRODUCES HEALTH INSURANCE SCHEME

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Lalitpur Metropolitan City has started providing health insurance facilities to the residents of the metropolis through the Yal Health Service Centre in collaboration with the Patan Academy of Health Sciences.

Chiribabu Maharjan, Mayor of the Lalitpur Metropolitan City, inaugurated the health service centre at the Social Welfare Building in Ward No. 20 recently.

Mayor Maharjan said that people of the metropolis can take advantage of the health insurance service through the centre.

He said, "The health insurance service is the gift for the people of the metropolis."

He further said that although the health insurance service programme was started by the government in 2016, the metropolis delayed the service due to various reasons. Now, it has started the service by handing over the health insurance policy to two individuals with disabilities last month.

Illegal parrot trade continues unabated in Dhanusadham

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Feb. 15

The illegal parrot trade prohibited by law, is going on uninterrupted at the Dhanushadham fair in Dhanusha. These parrots, once abundant in the Tarai region are on the verge of extinction, and despite protective laws, illegal parrot trade is rampant in Dhanushadham fair.

The majority of individuals engaged in the parrot trade are Indians. A parrot dealer, who was selling caged parrots, mentioned that he sold one parrot for Rs. 600 to Rs. 800. The businessman, who preferred not to disclose his name and address, said that he was importing parrots from Bihar, India, and selling them in the fair.

The trader said that he was aware of the ban on parrot trade in Nepal but added that no one had intervened to stop it.

Local Dhuryodhan Mahato said that every Sunday in January, six or seven Indian traders arrived to sell parrots. He added that neither the police responsible for fair security nor the staff from the nearby forest office made any effort to control the illegal parrot trade.



PHOTO: TRN

Parrots in cages for sell.

Dev Narayan Mandal, President of Mithila Wildlife Trust Dhanusha, engaged in bird and wildlife conservation, said that according to the government's poultry policy issued in 2012, only chickens, ducks, quails, guinea fowl, turkeys, pigeons, ostriches and partridge are permitted for rearing.

According to Mandal, it is evident from the law that keeping birds other than those mentioned is prohibited. There is a protocol in place for handling birds not covered by the policy, as per the law, he added.

The Act stipulates fines of up to Rs. 1 million or imprisonment for up to 15 years, or both, for individuals engaged in illegal wildlife trade. Responsibility for enforcing these legal provisions in Nepal falls on various authorities, including the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation, the Department of Forest and Soil Conservation and its subordinate offices, the Divisional Forest Office, and the Police.

"The illegal bird trade has been overshadowed by the illegal trade of tigers, rhinos, and elephants, "Mandal added.

Bechan Chaudhary, Divisional Head of the Division Forest Office in Dhanusha, said that the parrot trade was illegal and such businessmen would be arrested and penalised.

Giant bell placed in Panchakot

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baglung, Feb. 15

Muktinath Mahaghanta, a gigantic b ell weighing 5,555 kilogram, has been placed in Panchakot, Baglung.

The bell which was placed as part of the plan to develop Panchakot as a religious tourism site is going to be founded by performing religious activities on the occasion of Ananta Shree Brahmandiya Mahayagya on February 21.

The bell named Mahaghanta is made up of five metals – gold, silver, copper, brass and iron. It cost around Rs. 20 million and took eight years to make the bell.

The bell has been placed near the foundation of the would-be constructed 108-feet-tall Bishwo Shanti Kalash.



PHOTO: TRN

A giant bell placed at Panchakot, Baglung.

FUTURE WATCH

16th Febryart to 22nd February 2024 — **Based on birth names** — D. N. Lohani

ARIES

An advantageous week is in the store. Celebrations or similar events will occur. Friends will cooperate. Trade and profession both will turn profitable. You are likely to tolerate stomach disorder on Thursday.

CANCER

Period till Sunday is better. Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. Expenditure will be more than your expectation on Monday and Tuesday. You will retain limited support from friends. Investment will generate a return. Travel is in store for you.

LIBRA

Expenditure level will rise. Worthless issues can increase expenses. Health-related expenses can rise during the initial period. Circumstances will improve from Monday. The family will provide some support. The technical line will turn profitable.

CAPRICORN

Doubts and confusion can reside within the self. Health disorder is predicted. Try to avoid minor cuts or bruises on Tuesday. Students will have to work harder. Long travel is not probable.

TAURUS

Good cause will increase your expenses. Income will exceed your expectations. Support provided by the family will guide you ahead. Students will have to work harder. Technical trade will turn profitable.

LEO

An improved week is in store for you. You will advance overcoming emerging challenges. The study will take a progressive course. You will win legal issues. Love life can face challenges.

SCORPIO

Work will be completed only after applying more effort. You will advance after the controversy. Regular gain will help in consolidating your financial position. Friends will cooperate. The study will take a progressive course.

AQUARIUS

Health-related expenses will rise. Travel is likely to be delayed. Employees will have to overcome obstacles. Unnecessary discussion can occur on Thursday.

GEMINI

You have to tackle numerous obstacles. Opponents will remain active. Business will continue as usual. Expenditure will go up. You have to treat others at your expense. The study will take a progressive course.

VIRGO

You may have to overcome some obstacles today. The remaining period is better. Love life will take a progressive course. You will remove business-related obstacles. Students will have to work harder.

SAGITTARIUS

Expenditure level will rise. You will have to tackle numerous challenges. The family will provide good support. Love life will take a progressive course. Decisive ability will guide you ahead.

PISCES

Stomach disorder is predicted for mid-period. Feeding dogs can be useful in reducing malefic effects. Income and expenditure will maintain a balance. Businesses will provide ordinary returns. Study will keep you busy.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Following the light of the sun, we left the Old World.
- Christopher Columbus

EDITORIAL

Soil Friendly Farming

Soil is the foundation of agriculture. And agriculture has been the foundation of human civilisations, providing food and resources necessary for survival and allowing societies to flourish and develop. Often overlooked, soil is one of the most underappreciated of things. But it plays a crucial role in sustaining plant life and is essential for food production. President Ramchandra Paudel has rightly stressed the need for soil-friendly farming, explaining the criticality of modernising traditional agricultural practices to produce enough food to feed and nourish the country's population.

For this, the President stated that farmers should opt for soil-friendly farming that aligns with altitude. Agricultural yield is determined by the soil conditions, which is heavily influenced by climatic conditions linked with altitudes. Giving due attention to this fact in a country marked by altitudinal variations can well mean harnessing the blessings of nature. President Paudel also rightly pointed out the necessity of agricultural revolution that creates plenty of jobs in the sector and checks youth exodus, as well as lays the foundation of development.

Yet, soil crisis is brewing in many regions of the world. The Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) of the UN warned in 2022 that 90 per cent of the Earth's topsoil would be at risk by 2050. Topsoil is the layer of soil that contains the most organic matter and is the most fertile. It supports the growth of plants, which in turn provide habitat and food for other organisms. Its erosion means soil turning less fertile and reduced agricultural productivity, as well as decline of ecosystem nurtured by it. According to the UN, soil erosion may reduce 10 per cent of global crop yields by 2050. That crop loss is equivalent to removing millions of acres of farmland. In fact, a few centimetres of topsoil breathes life into all life forms inhabiting Earth and sustains biodiversity. Once that is gone, they will go, too.

In our context, sustainable farming underpinned by healthy soil and boosting agricultural productivity has become more urgent than ever, given our ballooning agricultural import, which hovered around Rs. 300 billion in this past fiscal year 2022/23, and skyrocketing food prices. When a necessity as basic as food forms the bulk of a country's import, prosperity remains a distant dream. Sustainable agriculture practice is crucial to produce good yields. Soil degradation resulting from poor agricultural practices coupled with climate-induced factors like changing rainfall patterns have put soil under enormous stress.

Sustainable agriculture promotes crop diversity by encouraging the cultivation of multiple crops in the same area, a practice essential to enhance soil health, reduce pests and diseases, and combat climate change. It is also the bedrock of organic and environmentally friendly food production system. Additionally, diverse crops contribute to food security, provide habitat for beneficial organisms, and preserve traditional farming knowledge.

Such a practice also goes a long way not only to promote soil health, conserve water resources and biodiversity but also protect environment and address climate concerns. Alarmed by the exacerbating soil crisis and the looming food insecurity, many people are joining campaigns to save the precious resource. Soil is degrading at a far higher rate than it can be replenished back to health condition. So, saving it has become so urgent. This is because to create an inch of soil, it takes 500 to a thousand years, but losing it takes no time.

Curb Organised Crimes

BINI DAHAL

These days, crimes are becoming more and more complex. It has especially become hard to keep track of, investigate and prevent them, particularly organised crimes. Organised crimes refer to such well-planned serious crimes that are committed by more than two individuals or by criminal groups with the intent of gaining certain money or profit. These crimes are highly complex as they are not limited to a certain individual or a certain country. Rather they are international or transnational in nature. With the world making rapid progress in science and technology, it has been used as a weapon by the criminals to make organised crimes more sophisticated.

When we talk about organised crimes, we cannot miss talking about nations like Nepal. For a long time, Nepal has been considered a fertile ground for organised crimes. The country is also considered a transit nation for criminals to carry out their transnational activities with ease. There are various types of organised crimes including human trafficking, drug trafficking, cybercrimes and financial frauds, among others. Recently, we have been hearing a lot about gold smuggling. Incidents of individuals hiding large amounts of gold and getting caught by the airport authorities is not uncommon.

Additionally, criminals smuggle gold transnationally, making Nepal as a transit hub. In the past, news reports have mentioned how Nepali politicians are also involved in such crimes. Involvement of those who are in power mainly boosts the confidence of the criminals and motivates them to continue their crimes.

The Nepal Police have recently uncovered a shocking incident. Based on a tip off, the police have rescued Indian nationals from Ratopul, Kathmandu. Apparently, these individuals had been promised that they would be taken to the United States. However, they were brought to Nepal and were locked up in a rented house for more than a month. The police have arrested individuals who were involved in this human trafficking. Preliminary investigation shows that the victims had paid up to Rs. 4.5 million. This incident alone stands as a perfect example of a type of organied crime.

Nepal's biggest weakness lies in its inability to strictly implement policies in place and also the lack of strict monitoring. The country has come up with its Organised Crime Prevention Act, 2070 B.S. and is also a signatory to the United Nations Convention Against Transnational Crimes. Open borders and a lack of strict border security and monitoring has posed a serious problem for us. Also, we are way behind when it comes to the use of science and technology. The proper utilisation of science and technology to promote surveillance, monitoring and investigation and for intelligence gathering can help minimise such crimes.

Especially when it comes to transnational crimes, close coordination with the authorities from the relevant countries is necessary. Maintaining peace and security and ensuring the safety of the people living in the country is always a priority. It is our responsibility to ensure that we do not provide our land as a fertile land for cunning criminal offenders to come into the country and commit the crime with ease. Authorities deserve kudos for their proactiveness to reduce organised crimes in the country.

Budget Must Stimulate Economy



Lok Deep Thapa

The budget is announced every year like it happens in virtually all the countries of the world. It is no different in Nepal and we have to accept the fact that without `the announcement' of the budget, the country cannot move on without any fiscal targets. Though time and again entrepreneurs and experts give different views on the content of the budget, mostly we have found nothing unique or extraordinary in the many budgets we have seen so far. Taxes are always increased in certain items and just to make it populist, the salaries of civil servants are also increased. No mention is made of how the market prices also increase as soon as the salaries of the civil servants are raised.

And also no thought is given to the fact that the lucky enough individuals who work as civil servants make up only about ten per cent of the entire population. Others have to depend on the meagre salaries that they are being given in whatever sector they work in, the decision of the government just does not touch whatever organisation or individuals they work for. So one pleasing factor this time when the announcement of the budget is only months away, is the strong statement of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, as reported in this daily, is that he will 'terminate' the tradition of copying previous budgets.

Right observation

According to the report, in a discussion with the experts related to development and planning held last week in Kathmandu, PM Prachanda argued that the traditional budget system had been an 'obstruction' to the transformation of the nation. This is a right observation and in spite of the budget announcement we have seen year in and year out, the nation has not seen many changes or drastic transformation in its economy. Therefore, the focus must be on not only making populist budgets or budgets that constantly increases taxes only on certain sectors, but also in having a long term target to improve the overall economy of the country.

Just making a handful of civil servants or businessmen happy is not enough. The common people may have to go through rough times for some period, but the Nepali people are well known for their perseverance and they will bear with the tough times if they know the future will be better. In this regard, the Prime Minister is absolutely right in saying that every year new budgets would be introduced as the 'photocopy' of the previous year's budget, therefore he is committed that this time the government would prepare the budget on priorities after debating, holding discussions and soliciting suggestions from all the sectors on the government's policies, programmes and the budget.

There is no doubt that the suggestions of the experts and also the big tax paying industrialists are important to make any fiscal policy of the government a success. On this account, the voice of the general citizens may go unheard. But what the planners and the architects of the budget must not forget is, they just cannot keep on burdening the common people with more taxes. Putting taxes on luxury items is quite understandable, but not to the extent that these items mostly become out of the reach of the ordinary masses.

> But what the planners and the architects of the budget must not forget is, they just cannot keep on burdening the common people with more taxes.

There was once a time when a similar policy was implemented by India, but after the introduction of a free market policy, look at how that country's economy has made progress by leaps and bounds. So only increasing taxes will not be enough, let the market decide on how it can flow smoothly and still contribute significantly towards the country's economy. The same can be said about China. The government there may have still put on certain restrictions, but after it opted to go for a free market economy, it has taken a huge leap forward, more than what its founder rulers did. In fact now, China and India are two of the largest economic powers of the world and they did this with sound policies and not only raising taxes.

Lesson from neighbours

Nepal can learn and also benefit from the experiences of two of its neighbours. It can see much economic development by just hanging on to the enormous economic gains made by these nations which are now major players in the international economy. For instance, we can just look at the stable currency of both these countries, which have made them very competitive in the international scenario. Also look at how these countries have focused on local production rather than imports alone and contributed more to their national economy. For example, vehicles were much cheaper here in Nepal in the past, but due to hikes in taxes, they cost much more than the locally produced international brands of vehicles available in both these countries.

Of course, we cannot expect to see a drastic scenario in our economy at the wave of a wand, but some pragmatic policies have to start sometime or the other. That is why the budget must not be taken as only the summing up of the expenditures of the government for one fiscal year. The experts and planners must see to it that the budget also has a far-reaching effect on the economy in the years to come. Just bringing out a balance sheet of expenditures will not make the economy healthy and robust. For the entire people to see prosperity and progress, more long-term ideas will have to be implemented. If we have to learn from other countries, including our two immediate neighbours, so be it, especially for our national interest and even if we have to tighten our belts for some time to come, we must be prepared for such times.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

Road Safety Vital For Healthier Society



Dr. Pushpa R. Joshi

Road traffic injuries represent a significant but often overlooked public health crisis, demanding unified and sustained efforts for comprehensive and enduring prevention. Among the myriad systems that individuals encounter daily, road traffic systems stand out as the most intricate and dangerous. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), an alarming 1.2 million people lose their lives annually due to road traffic crashes and as many as 50 million are injured. In fact, road traffic injuries are emerging as the primary cause of death for individuals aged 5–29 years. Furthermore, it is noteworthy that a staggering 92 per cent of global road fatalities transpire in low- and middle-income countries.

In Nepal, the road traffic injury mortality rate was 16 per 100,000 people in 2019, and there is a presumption that this figure has likely risen since then. Rapid urbanisation, coupled with advancements in technology and a surge in vehicular traffic, has presented significant challenges to road safety in Nepal. This issue is a pivotal concern in the pursuit of a healthier and safer society. The intricate relationship between road safety and public health emphasises the multifaceted benefits of prioritising safety on our roads.

Medical attention

Accidents often lead to physical injuries that require medical attention. Beyond the physical injuries sustained in accidents, road safety directly influences the overall health of individuals. Long-term consequences can include disabilities that affect the overall well-being of the people. The mental health of survivors and witnesses may also be impacted, leading to conditions such as post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and anxiety. Preventing accidents minimises fatalities, disabilities, and other health issues. Furthermore, a safer road environment contributes to improved mental health, reducing stress and anxiety associated with the fear of accidents.

Underscoring the importance of this matter, the WHO and the World Bank had collaboratively released the inaugural World Report on Road Traffic Injury Prevention in 2004. Since then, this initiative has achieved significant milestones, culminating in the unveiling of the fifth Global Status Report on Road Safety in December 2023. This ongoing commitment reflects the dedication of these global communities towards addressing and improving road safety on a comprehensive scale.

The interplay of equity, social, and environmental determinants significantly influences both road safety and public health outcomes. Generally, vulnerable populations, such as pedestrians, children, cyclists, and those with limited access to education and resources, are disproportionately affected by road accidents. Hence, equity considerations underscore the importance of ensuring fair access to safe transportation infrastructure and resources for all individuals, irrespective of socio-economic factors. Social determinants, including cultural norms, education levels, and community cohesion, also play a pivotal role in shaping road safety behaviours and outcomes.

Meanwhile, environmental factors such as urban planning, traffic management, and the presence of pedestrian-friendly spaces contribute to the overall safety of road users and the surrounding community. Recognising and addressing these determinants are crucial for developing effective and inclusive strategies to enhance road safety and public health. To achieve effective road safety measures, collaboration among experts, engineers, bureaucrats, and policymakers is essential. However, in Nepal, political influences often override this cooperation, leading to poorly planned projects. For instance, the recently inaugurated dedicated fast lane for buses in Ratnapark-Suryabinayak route deviates from global safety standards and lacks proper guidance for users, increasing accident risks.

> The interplay of equity, social, and environmental determinants significantly influences both road safety and public health outcomes.

Similarly, bicycle lanes inaugurated in 2019 in Lalitpur suffer from inadequate enforcement and dangerous placement within regular traffic lanes. These failures underscore the need for comprehensive SWOT (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats) analyses and adherence to expert recommendations in road safety initiatives. Implementing comprehensive public health interventions is essential for enhancing road safety. Key components contributing to a holistic approach include education and awareness campaigns. These involve the development and implementation of widespread educational programmes targeting diverse populations to raise awareness about the importance of road safety rules, responsible driving, and the risks associated with unsafe traffic behaviors.

Community engagement is another vital aspect, emphasising the need for community involvement in road safety initiatives to address local needs. Encouraging community-based organisations to promote safe traffic practices and cultivate a culture of accountability plays a crucial role in fostering a sense of shared responsibility for road safety. Enforcement of traffic laws is pivotal for ensuring adherence to regulations. This component advocates for the strengthening of law enforcement measures and the implementation of strict penalties for violations to deter unsafe behaviors and enhance compliance.

Infrastructure

Infrastructure improvement focuses on investing in the design and maintenance of road infrastructure with a safety-centric approach. This includes integrating features such as pedestrian-friendly crossings, modern traffic lights, well-marked lanes, and adequate signage to create safer environments for all road users. Vehicle safety standards constitute another key element, urging the enforcement and enhancement of standards to reduce the risk of accidents. Promoting the use of safety technologies, such as airbags and anti-lock brakes, in all vehicles contributes to overall road safety.

To summarise, effective interventions in road safety rely on robust data collection and analysis, identifying trends and high-risk areas. Strengthening emergency trauma services ensures swift and efficient care for victims, while paramedic training improves response to traffic-related emergencies. Collaboration among government, non-profits, and healthcare providers enhances intervention effectiveness through pooled resources. Integration with public health programmes addresses holistic health issues, emphasising the importance of enforcing traffic laws, infrastructure improvement, public awareness, and enhanced emergency services for a safer society.

(The author is a senior scientist based in Germany pushpa.joshi@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 16, 1974

Flower Show To Be Held

Kathmandu, Feb 15: A flower exhibition will be held at Bhrikutimandap for three days towards the third of April, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Give Priority To Road Safety

This is in reference to a news report titled *"10 people killed in road accident in Kapilvastu"* published on 15th February, 2024 in the digital edition of your prestigious daily. According to the news report, ten people lost their lives after a bus travelling from Kathmandu to Mahendrapur fell some 200 metres below from the road at around 1: 00 am. This accident took place near the Surahi bridge in Shivaraj Municipality-1, Kapilvastu.

Thirty passengers were injured in the incident of which nine were rushed to a hospital in Butwal. The remaining are said to be receiving medical treatments in local medical centres.

Road accidents are really common in Nepal. Especially night buses running long distances are more prone to road accidents. The infrastructures are not good enough. Because it is night time and most rural areas do not have street lamps, it can be difficult navigating the road.

Also the road conditions are not good



enough, so drivers are always forced to risk their lives while driving. And there are also instances where it is the fault of the drivers. Driving under the influence of alcohol and making the same driver drive such a long distance, without having an extra driver, increases the risks of fatal accidents.

The authorities should collaborate and cooperate with private transportation companies to ensure greater safety when driving. The importance of good road infrastructure can never be stressed enough.

Aakriti Poudel
Ratopul, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

Finding one of her students making faces at others on the playground, Ms. Smith stopped to gently reprove the child.

Smiling sweetly, the teacher said, "Bobby, when I was a child, I was told that if I made ugly faces, it would freeze and I would stay like that."

Bobby looked up and replied, "Well, Ms. Smith, you can't say you weren't warned."

+++++

A man was driving down the road. He passed a traffic camera and saw it flash.

Astounded that he had been caught speeding when he was doing the speed limit, he turned around and, going even slower, he passed the camera.

Again, he saw it flash. He couldn't believe it!

So he turned and, going a snail's pace, he passed the camera. Again, he saw the camera flash. He guessed it must have a fault, and home he went.

Four weeks later he received 3 traffic fines in the mail, all for not wearing a seat belt.

Israeli forces storm Nasser Hospital in southern Gaza



PHOTO: AP

Civil defense and rescue workers remove rubbles from a building that was attacked Wednesday night by an Israeli airstrike, in Nabatiyeh town, south Lebanon, Thursday, Feb. 15, 2024.

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Feb. 15

Israeli forces stormed the main hospital in southern Gaza on Thursday, hours after Israeli fire killed a patient and wounded six others inside the complex, the Gaza Health Ministry said.

The raid came a day after the army sought to evacuate thousands of displaced people who had taken shelter at the Nasser Hospital in Khan Younis. The southern city has been the main target of Israel's offensive against Hamas in recent weeks.

Separately, Israeli airstrikes killed at least 13 people in southern Lebanon on Wednesday, 10 civilians — mostly women and children — and three fighters from the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah, an ally of Gaza's Hamas militants. The strikes came just hours after a rocket attack from Lebanon killed an Israeli soldier in what was the deadliest of daily exchanges of fire along the border since the Oct. 7 start of the war in Gaza. It also underscored the risks of a broader conflict.

Negotiations over a cease-fire in Gaza appear to have stalled, and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has vowed to continue the offensive until Hamas is destroyed and scores of hostages taken during the Oct. 7 attack that sparked the war are returned.

Nasser Hospital, in the southern city of Khan Younis, has been the latest focus of operations that have gutted Gaza's health sector as it struggles to treat scores of patients wounded in daily bombardments. Israel accuses Hamas of using hospitals and other civilian structures to shield its fighters.

Video of the aftermath of the strike showed medics scrambling to wheel patients on stretchers through a corridor filled with smoke or dust.

A medic used a cellphone flashlight to illuminate a darkened room where a wounded man screamed out in pain as gunfire echoed outside. The Associated Press could not authenticate the videos but they were consistent with its reporting.

Dr. Khaled Alserr, one of the remaining surgeons at Nasser Hospital, told the AP that the seven patients hit early Thursday were already being treated for past wounds. On Wednesday, a doctor was lightly wounded when a drone opened fire on the upper stories of the hospital, he said.

"The situation is escalating every hour and every minute," he said.

The Israeli military said Wednesday that it had opened a secure corridor for displaced people to leave the hospital but would allow doctors and patients to remain there. Videos circulating online showed scores of people walking out of the facility on foot carrying their belongings on their shoulders.

The military had ordered the evacuation of Nasser Hospital and surrounding areas last month. But as with other health facilities, medics said patients were unable to safely leave or be relocated, and thousands of people displaced by fighting elsewhere remained there. Palestinians say nowhere is safe in the besieged territory, as Israel continues to carry out strikes in all parts of it.

France, Ukraine to sign security agreement



PHOTO: AP

French President Emmanuel Macron, right, welcomes Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy at the Elysee palace in Paris, May 14, 2023. French President Emmanuel will sign a bilateral security agreement with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Friday Feb.16, 2024 in Paris as part of a trip to Germany and France, the French presidency said in a statement.

AP
Paris, Feb. 15

French President Emmanuel Macron will sign a bilateral security agreement with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Friday in Paris as part of a trip that will also go through Germany, the French presidency said in a statement.

It did not release specific details about the agreement, to be signed at the Elysee presidential palace.

Macron said earlier this year that France was negotiating a bilateral deal on the model the one Ukraine recently agreed with the United Kingdom, which covers 10 years.

This will be the third visit by Zelenskyy to Paris since Russia's invasion of Ukraine almost two years ago, following those in February and May 2023, the statement said.

The French presidency said the visit will be an opportunity for Macron "to reaffirm France's determination to continue to provide unwavering support to Ukraine and the Ukrainian people, over the long term and with all its partners."

Both leaders will discuss the situation on the front line, Ukraine's military, economic and humanitarian needs, as well as negotiations on the country's efforts to join the European Union, which France fully supports, the statement said.

'Turkey, Egypt gain new height in relations'

AFP
Cairo, Feb. 15

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and his Egyptian counterpart Abdel Fattah al-Sisi said in Cairo on Wednesday that they were turning a "new leaf" in their relations after over a decade of estrangement.

The two leaders also criticised Israel's conduct of the war in the Gaza Strip and called for a ceasefire.

Sisi welcomed Erdogan with great fanfare at Cairo airport before the pair signed several agreements.

They both called for "a new stage in relations", an increase in trade to "$15 billion per year within a few years" and diplomatic cooperation in the Middle East.

Erdogan, an outspoken critic of Israel's conduct in its war with Gaza's rulers Hamas, again took aim at the government of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

The Turkish leader, on his first visit to Egypt in more than 10 years, denounced Netanyahu's "occupation, destruction and massacres".

Erdogan said the Palestinians were "at the top of our agenda" and that it was "our priority to establish a ceasefire as soon as possible".

Turkey was "ready to work with Egypt for the recovery and reconstruction of Gaza in the medium term," he added.

For his part, Sisi criticised "Israel's obstacles which mean that humanitarian aid enters Gaza too slowly".

Egypt controls the Rafah crossing into Gaza, but Israel insists on inspecting every aid shipment.

Cairo has been hosting joint efforts with Qatar and the United States to broker a new truce between Israel and Hamas.

An Israel delegation was in Cairo on Tuesday, while a Hamas delegation was to travel to the Egyptian capital on Wednesday.

Turkey and Egypt cut ties in 2013 after Sisi, then defence minister, ousted Islamist president Mohamed Morsi, an ally of Ankara and part of the Muslim Brotherhood movement.

At the time, Erdogan said he would never speak to "anyone" like Sisi, who in 2014 became president of the Arab world's most populous nation.

But relations have thawed since 2021, when a Turkish delegation visited Egypt to discuss normalisation.

By last July, Cairo and Ankara had appointed ambassadors to each other's capitals for the first time in a decade.

US Democrats embrace tougher border enforcement



PHOTO: AP

Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer, D-N.Y., speaks to at the Capitol in Washington, Tuesday, Feb. 13, 2024.

AP
Washington, Feb. 15

The Senate's border proposal was one of the toughest bipartisan bills to emerge on the issue in decades. Yet it quickly collapsed when Republicans — galvanized by Donald Trump, the likely Republican presidential nominee — rejected the compromise as insufficient.

Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer called Trump's rejection of the border legislation "a gift" for Democrats and said they plan to "constantly over the next year" remind voters that it was Republicans who torpedoed the deal. And he says the strategy has already paid dividends, with Democrat Tom Suozzi, who campaigned on tougher border enforcement, winning a special election this week in New York, flipping a House seat away from Republicans.

Schumer said the race in his home state of New York "says something very significant — that border is no longer the province of Republicans."

That calculation is already having far-reaching effects, transforming the way President Joe Biden and Democrats talk about one of the biggest issues in this year's elections and shaping the policy debate over immigration.

It's a strategy with significant political risk. Republicans have campaigned on border security for years, and public frustration is running high with the record number of illegal U.S. border crossings. While arrests for illegal border crossings dipped by half in January, they reached 249,735 in December, the highest monthly tally on record. Cities, including many run by Democratic mayors, are straining under an influx of migrants.

Republicans pin the historic number of illegal border crossings directly on Biden and argue that the Senate legislation would not have been enough to curb it. They say Democrats are only trying to excuse away their own failures.

Sen. John Cornyn, a Texas Republican, said earlier this month that the influx of migrants "burdening my state and a lot of the major cities around the country is unsustainable and has proven to be a political liability for President Biden, so they want to try to act like they're doing something about it for a fig leaf."

PRISM

Australian beach hosts ice bath

Fremantle: A health and wellness company in Australia set a Guinness World Record when 509 people took ice baths at the same time on a beach.

One Life Live It organized the attempt at the record for the most people taking an ice bath simultaneously at Leighton Beach in Fremantle, Western Australia. The company set up large, inflatable pools on the beach and the participants entered together, with about 12 bathers in each pool.

Participants were required to remain submerged up to their necks for at least 3 minutes to qualify for the record. A total 537 people made the attempt, but only 509 managed to go the distance. A Guinness World Records adjudicator was present to give an official certificate to organizers.

Tiny cubs lead mother across bridge

MalaMala: Chad Hobbs captured this adorable scene at MalaMala Game Reserve in South Africa, and the cute footage was shared with LatestSightings.com.

Lions are known to be fierce and unforgiving beasts, but there's also a very different side to lions. Like fluffy balls of cuteness, that are lion cubs. These guys are tiny, with the cutest round shape, short, stout legs and big, pearly eyes.

On this particular day, on MalaMala's West Bridge, which crosses over the sand river, The resident pride of lions had been lazing and relaxing. With the adults being lazy cats, the cubs were getting impatient.

(AP)

Australian PM says his marriage proposal is accepted

AP
Melbourne, Australia, Feb. 15

Anthony Albanese has become the first Australian prime minister to get engaged while in office, revealing Thursday that his partner accepted his marriage proposal on Valentine's Day.

He and Jodie Haydon, a financial services professional, have been together for three years. Albanese said he proposed on a balcony of his official residence, known as the Lodge, following a romantic dinner at an Italian restaurant.

"She said yes," Albanese posted with a love heart symbol on the X social media platform.

The first-term prime minister said he had planned both the date and place of the proposal and even helped design Haydon's diamond ring. But he did not know if the wedding would be held before he sets the date for Australia's next election, sometime between this August and May of next year.



PHOTO: AP

Anthony Albanese, right, smiles as his partner Jodie Haydon blows him a kiss while thanking supporters at a Labour Party event in Sydney, Australia, May 22, 2022, following a national election. Albanese has become the first Australian prime minister to get engaged while in office, revealing Thursday, Feb. 15, 2024, that his partner Haydon accepted his marriage proposal on Valentine's Day.

"We'll now have those discussions between us, which I think people would understand, and sort out those details, but we just want to live in the moment at this point," Albanese told reporters at a brief news conference on a lawn outside the Lodge.

"It is such a joy to be able to share this news with people and it's wonderful I found a partner who I want to spend the rest of my life with.

Last night was a very great occasion here at the Lodge. We couldn't be more happy," he added.

Haydon thanked friends, family and strangers for their messages of congratulation. "It's just been overwhelming, but beautiful," Haydon said.

Albanese, 60, has an adult son with his first wife.

They divorced after a 19-year marriage.

Opposition leader Peter Dutton offered Albanese light-hearted congratulations in Parliament, hinting at their differences over whether King Charles III should remain Australia's head of state.

Dutton wants the British monarch to remain Australia's monarch. Albanese wants Australia to become a republic with an Australian head of state.

"We look forward to our version of the royal wedding some time in the near future," Dutton said, prompting laughter from his colleagues.

"I'll be there, throwing roses out in front of you, prime minister. Whatever it takes to get an invite to the gala wedding," Dutton added.

Albanese is only the second prime minister to live with a common law partner at the Lodge.

Julia Gillard led the government from 2010 until 2013, and the unusual status of her partner reportedly delayed Indonesia issuing him a visa when she made an official visit to the country in 2011.

In neighbouring New Zealand, former Prime Minister Jacinda Ardern married longtime partner Clarke Gayford in January after becoming engaged while she was in office almost five years earlier.

She resigned as prime minister last year.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1249 – Andrew of Longjumeau is dispatched by Louis IX of France as his ambassador to meet with the Khagan of the Mongol Empire.

1630 – Dutch forces led by Hendrick Lonck capture Olinda in what was to become part of Dutch Brazil.

1646 – Battle of Torrington, Devon: The last major battle of the First English Civil War.

1943 – World War II: In the early phases of the Third Battle of Kharkov, Red Army troops re-enter the city.

1945 – The Alaska Equal Rights Act of 1945, the first anti-discrimination law in the United States, was signed into law.

1960 – The U.S. Navy submarine USS Triton begins Operation Sandblast, setting sail from New London, Connecticut, to begin the first submerged circumnavigation of the globe.

NOC HIKES PETROL, DIESEL PRICES BY RS. 2 EACH

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Nepal Oil Corporation has increased the prices of petroleum products.

A meeting of the NOC's Board of Directors held on Thursday evening decided to increase the prices of petrol, diesel and kerosene effective from Thursday midnight.

According to the Corporation, the price of petrol, diesel and kerosene has increased by Rs. 2 per litre each.

According to the new prices, the price of petrol in Kathmandu Valley has increased to Rs. 172 per litre while the price of diesel and kerosene increased to Rs. 160 per litre each.

Similarly, petrol will now cost Rs. 169.5 per litre in the first category and Rs. 171 in the second category.

The price of diesel and kerosene will now cost Rs. 157.5 per litre in the first category and Rs. 159 in the second category.

The NOC said that the prices of aviation fuel and cooking gas have remained unchanged.

The price of cooking gas is Rs. 1,910 per cylinder.

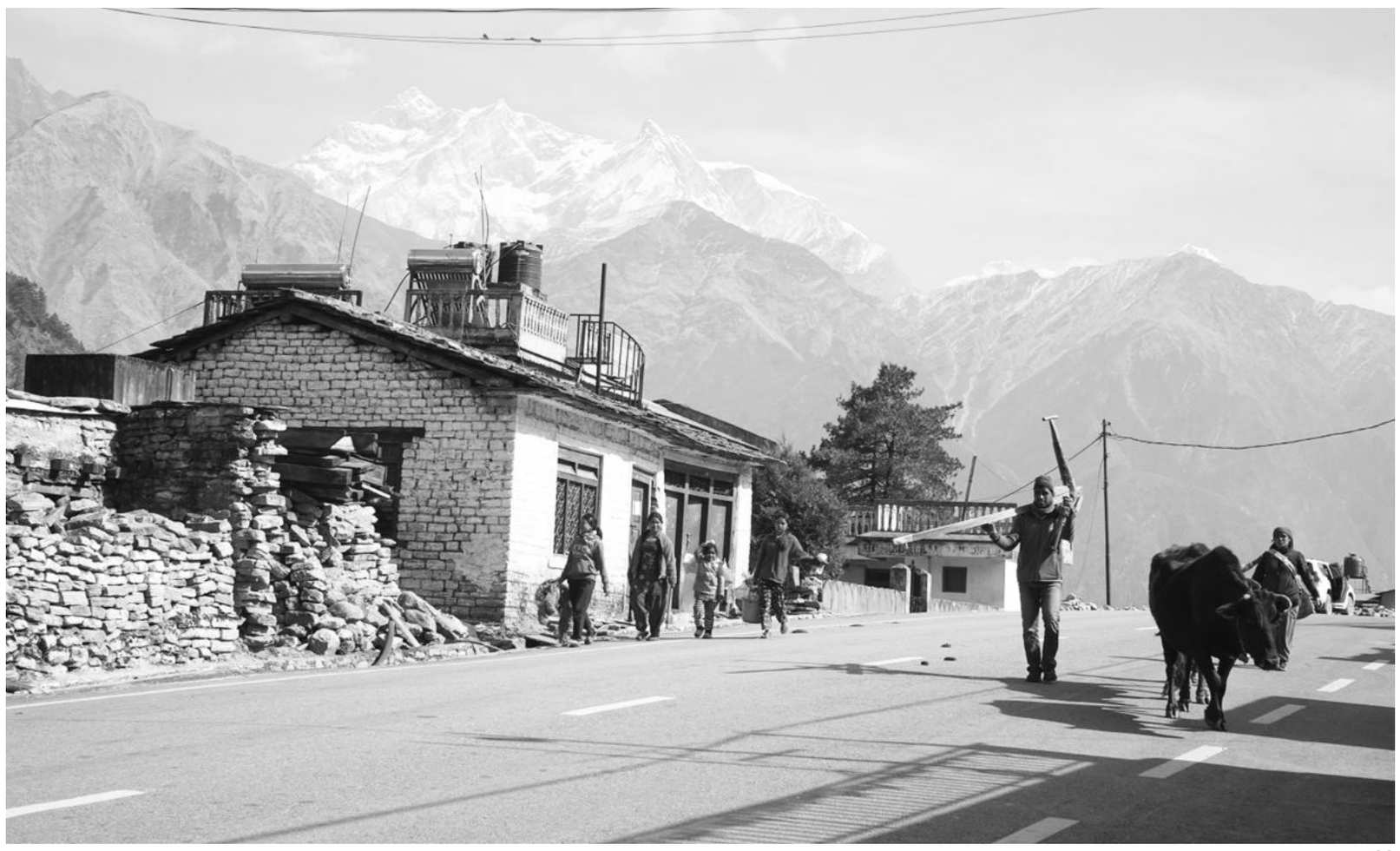


PHOTO: RSS

Farmers heading towards their working place with their oxen in Thasang of Mustang district. Annapurna Mountain is seen in the background.

NC CONTINUES PREPARATIONS FOR MAHASAMITI MEETING

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

The Nepali Congress (NC) Central Working Committee (CWC) meeting was held at the party's central office in Sanepa, Lalitpur on Thursday.

The primary agenda of the meeting was to manage and coordinate the arrangements for the upcoming General Committee (Mahasamiti) meeting scheduled at Godavari in Lalitpur from February 19 to 22.

Party spokesperson and Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat briefed about the progress made for the Mahasamiti meeting. Furthermore, general secretaries Gagan Kumar Thapa and Bishwa Prakash Sharma presented various political and organisational proposals to enhance the NC's presence in the public.

The primary agenda of the meeting was to manage and coordinate the arrangements for the upcoming General Committee (Mahasamiti) meeting scheduled at Godavari in Lalitpur from February 19 to 22.

The NC has intensified its efforts to ensure the smooth holding of the Mahasamiti meeting, transforming it into a comprehensive 'policy session'. To facilitate this, nine distinct sub-committees have been formed to manage various aspects of the event efficiently. Under the leadership of the party President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba, these sub-committees have been entrusted with specific responsibilities to make all required arrangements for the meeting.

Meen Bishwakarma, the head of the party's information, communication, and publicity department, disclosed that the sub-committees have already commenced their respective tasks. Particularly, a proposal preparation committee, under the coordination of party Vice-President Purna Bahadur Khadka, has been formed to draft policy proposals to present in the Mahasamiti meeting.

The organisational report of the party will be presented by general secretaries Gagan Kumar Thapa and Bishwa Prakash Sharma. In addition to the official proceedings, the NC plans to host a blood donation programme and a health camp during the event, demonstrating its commitment to social welfare activities.

To ensure seamless communication and dissemination of information, the party will establish a media centre and information centre equipped with modern technology. Further, arrangements for logistics, accommodation, and catering for the event participants have been meticulously organised.

Over 2,000 delegates are expected at the gathering.

Municipalities help communities to preserve water springs

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Seven municipalities of the district have backed the campaign to revive drying springs and pledged to adopt community-led solutions to address growing water insecurity.

Municipalities in Kavrepalanchowk are taking initiatives to address the problem of water shortage by supporting community-led solutions to conserve water springs.

Seven municipalities of the district have backed the campaign to revive drying springs and pledged to adopt community-led solutions to address growing water insecurity.

A survey conducted in 2023 of 444 springs in Namobuddha Municipality found that nearly 20 per cent (93 springs) had dried up, with many others reporting a decline in water discharge.

Namobuddha, Panauti, Dhulikhel and Panchkhaal municilaities and Roshi, Bethanchowk and Temal rural municipalities have signed an agreement with the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) to roll out an innovative Nature-based Solution (NbS) to water shortage.

An estimated 9 million springs are in the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) region which serve as a critical water source for some 100 million people. However, springs are disappearing across the HKH due to climate change, over-extraction of groundwater, and land cover and land use change, exacerbated by road constructions leading to erosion and rock instability, read a press statement issued by ICIMOD on Thursday.

Water experts hope the landmark agreement will inspire other municipalities in Nepal and across the region, where water stress is already at a critical level particularly during dry seasons, to adopt spring shed management in their budgets and plans, read the press release.

"The disappearance of springs across the Hindu Kush Himalayas is a silent disaster," said Sanjeev Bhuchar, Intervention Manager of the springs programme at ICIMOD. The issue has not received enough attention or investment, but these problems should be stressed to ensure mountain communities have continued access to drinking water, and water for livestock and crops and to prevent distress migration.

"The good news is that it is possible to bring springs back – to the huge benefit of communities across the mountains, and especially for women and adolescent girls, who bear an unequal burden of provisioning water for the household. We are delighted that municipalities in Kavre are taking this leadership role in sustaining water sources in the hills."

Under the agreement, ICIMOD will help municipalities undertake an inventory of springs in their area, with details of their location and status, implement recharge interventions based on a study of the hydrogeology, and validate estimates of improved spring flows and water quality, and additional biodiversity and climate co-benefits. The analysis is designed to demonstrate a workable model that can be replicated in other areas where springs are drying up.

Pema Gyamtsho, Director General, ICIMOD said, "All our eight member countries have cited water insecurity and its impact on people, livelihoods and biodiversity, as a major concern, which is why we now have it as such a major focus of our work. I am delighted to see these municipalities leap deploying these crucial, socially inclusive and gender-responsive solutions to address and prevent further water stress in the region."

ICIMOD's Springs workstream is part of the Himalayan Resilience Enabling Action Programme (HI-REAP), supported by the Foreign Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO), Government of the United Kingdom under their Climate Action for Resilient Asia (CARA) initiative, with co-financing from Frank Water, a social enterprise working on alleviating global water poverty.

It might take additional...

enrolment rates, women and girls in the region continue to face considerable challenges when it comes to accessing education and employment opportunities. They have lower enrolment rates and struggle with literacy. Young women also encounter difficulties accessing labour markets, leading to higher rates of youth unemployment. Meanwhile, the challenges faced by men tend to be related to their health or personal safety. They suffer from higher rates of suicide, chronic diseases and road traffic deaths.

"While additional efforts are required across the board, granular data emphasises the urgency of addressing inequalities that impact marginalised groups, including women, girls, rural populations and the urban poor, who continue to find themselves locked out of education and employment opportunities," said United Nations Under-Secretary-General and Executive Secretary of ESCAP, Armida Salsiah Alisjahbana.

She added that the sustained progress gap revealed between countries in special situations, especially Pacific Small Island Developing States, and the rest of the region demands a concerted response from international, regional and national partners.

"People living in rural areas face pronounced disadvantages, such as limited access to basic drinking water and sanitation facilities. Additionally, the lower availability of clean cooking fuels in these areas contributes to serious respiratory diseases," read the report. In general, urban areas exhibit better conditions, yet paradoxically, within these areas, the poorest boys and girls face significant hurdles in completing upper secondary education.

On a more encouraging note, the report shares several laudable national success stories in supporting at-risk population groups. In the Philippines, dedicated research and analysis aimed at estimating the cost of supporting children living with a disability played a pivotal role in influencing recent legislation to provide a disability allowance, extending support to children with disabilities.

Nationwide digital training programmes in Viet Nam have underscored the value of public-private partnerships in accelerating digital transformation and bridging the skills and employment gap for youth and migrant workers. Meanwhile, in North and Central Asia, national statistical systems in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan have been upgraded to better support stateless populations.

PM stresses initiatives...

The three-day event was hosted by Kathmandu University and organised by the Association of Indian Universities (AIU)-North Zone. According to Kathmandu University, the conclave with the theme 'Globalisation and Internationalisation of Higher Education' will help explore the impact of globalisation on higher education institutions, fostering international collaboration and idea exchange.

According to Ekku Maya Pun, the Spokesperson for the university, the event will explore the impact of globalisation on higher education institutions, international cooperation and exchange of ideas, building common assembly networks, best partnership practices and also promote the exchange of cultural ideas among academic communities, especially within the South Asian region.

She said that the participants focused on the value of international collaborations between higher education institutions and highlighted the benefits of research partnerships, student exchange programmes, joint degree programmes, and faculty collaborations across borders in the first session.

In the second session, the participants are expected to address the regulatory and policy considerations in global higher education by deliberating on topics such as accreditation standards, quality assurance mechanisms and others. Similarly, in the third session, they will focus on ways to promote students' mobility while fostering an inclusive, welcoming and culturally diverse learning environment on campuses for success in a globalised world.

President of the AIU Prof. GD Sharma, Vice Chancellor of Kathmandu University Prof. Dr. Bhola Thapa, Vice Chairman of AIU and Vice Chancellor of Chhatrapati Sahu Ji Maharaj University Vinay Kumar Pathak including 237 Vice-Chancellors and education experts from 150 universities of Nepal, India, South-East Asian region, Europe, Africa and Australia are attending the Summit.

Milky way project brings smiles...

year is expected to reach 250,000 litres a month.

The municipality is working on a plan to create a value chain, diversify milk products and make it self-reliant in this sector. Of about 5,500 families here, 3,000 to 4,000 are involved in agriculture.

"We are in discourse with the Dairy Development Corporation and Sujal Dairy to manage the market for the milk produced here and other milk products," said Pokharel.

Meanwhile, farmers are expecting to earn about Rs. 50,000 to Rs. 60,000 a month from a single cow. It will make some visible impacts on the local economy, livestock development and farmers' lifestyle. They will have more economic resources at their disposal and can further expand their farm and farming.

Secretary Dr. Poudel praised the progress of the Milky Way Project and said that the MoFALD felt a need for this programme should be replicated in many other areas across the country.

"A mechanism should be created to address the problems of farmers in animal husbandry, and MoALD is ready to support in financing, marketing and entrepreneurship development," he said, "We can learn more from the Korean practice and progress in this sector."

Likewise, Ambassador Tae-Young termed the calf handover a historic moment.

"This event happened while Nepal and South Korea are celebrating the Golden Jubilee of the establishment of diplomatic relations between the two countries," he said.

He also stated that this is the first case to walk with Nepali farmers and Korean experts and Korea expected to make this relationship a sustained one.

Special Court...

including Kalpana Tuladhar would be confiscated and brought under the government's registration.

As per the verdict, the Special Court has ordered the government to bring land in the government's ownership from Kalpana Tuladhar, Sharmila Shakya Bajracharya, Pragati Kansakar, the Non-Resident Nepali Association, Kamana Gurung, Kalyan Gurung, Sajjan Kumar Chachan, Devanshi Goyal, Saraswati Ghale Gurung, Sarala Ghale, Manoj Kumar Kediya, Manoj Kumar Gautam, Manti Gorkhali, Nirmala Devi Goyal and Nikita Tuladhar.

Similarly, the Court ordered to confiscate the land from Amitambh Tuladhar, Uma Prasai, Parishova Tuladhar, Renuka Bajracharya, Subista Tuladhar, Anjana Tuladhara Tamrakar, Chandrika Kansakar Tuladhar, Sanuchhori Bajracharya, Sipika Khetan, Sushma Bajracharya Shakya, Sandhya Shakya, Sangita Rakhecha (Kathori Bodhra), Nutan Shrestha, Dharmashova Shakya, Dimple Vansal, Sarita Manandhar Shrestha, Gita Gautam Khanal, Nitu Gurung, Rita Ojha Gautam, Ratnahira Bajracharya, and Pratima Vaidya Pradhan.

Likewise, it ordered to confiscate the land owned by Prabin Tamrakar, Bijaya Tamrakar, Maya Sherpa Gauchan, Maheshraja Tuladhar, Dwarika Devi Shrestha, Indradev Gurung, Indu Sharma, Sandeep Dhakal, Bhawani Joshi, Bharati Pandey, Bivek Kumar Subedi, Keshav Tuladhar, Anita Devi Kansakar, Om Birman Tamrakar, Anilman Tamrakara, Govindalal Sanghai, Gayatri Shrestha Kansakar, Panch Narayan Maharjan alias Sanukanchha, Radha Sigdel Acharya, Machababu Prajapati, Rupesh Kumar Subedi, Saroj Dhakal, Pahalman Gurung, Purushottam Paudel, Pramod Sherchan, Kanak Herbal, Achyutaraj Shrestha, Bijendra Joshi and Drilaxmi Shrestha.

European Bank likely to invest in large infra projects

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Ambassador of the European Union (EU) to Nepal Veronique Lorenzo has said that the European Investment Bank (EIB) is likely to invest in a couple of large infrastructure projects in Nepal.

50 YEARS OF EU-NEPAL TIES

Discussions are underway and we can hope for some good news by the end of this year, she said while speaking at an interaction with the journalists organised on the occasion of the 50 years of the establishment of political and economic relations between the EU and Nepal.

The EU and Nepal established political and economic relations in 1974 and signed a Cooperation Agreement on 1 June 1996. This year, they are celebrating 50 years of diplomatic relations with the slogan 'Growing Stronger Together'.

Stating that there has been a shift in the approach to the cooperation between the two friends, Lorenzo said that the Delegation of the EU in Nepal was working to attract funding from the member countries in Europe, development funding institutions and private sector investors.

She also said that her office in Kathmandu was closely working with the



Government of Nepal for the upcoming Nepal Investment Summit, slated for April 21-22, 2024.

"We coordinate and encourage European chambers of commerce and industries to come to Nepal and invest here. However, it is on the part of the government here to make a conducive environment that would attract investors," stated Ambassador Lorenzo.

Likewise, she said that to discourage the anti-democratic forces and activities, the government should make constant and effective delivery of services. The EU will continue to support the government as per the current programmes and policies of both parties.

According to the Delegation of the EU in Kathmandu, both partners have undergone important changes over the past 50 years. Nepal has become a Federal Democracy, whilst the European Economic Community became the European Union in 1993 and developed its common foreign and security policy in 2010, with the creation of the European External Action Service (EEAS).

Over this time, the two partners have expanded their democratic and economic space and strengthened their shared interests. Today, the EU and Nepal share the commitment to protect and promote a rule-based international order, peace and prosperity, human rights and democracy.

"This year we celebrate 50 years of steadfast partnership, which grows stronger every year with our unwavering commitments to work together for peace and prosperity," Ambassador Lorenzo said.

She added, "As Nepal advances towards graduating from LDC status by 2026, the EU and its Member States, our 'Team Europe', will continue to support Nepal in three areas key for its development: Inclusive Green Growth, Human Capital Development and Good Governance. As we move forward, the EU Global Gateway, our new comprehensive approach to investing in development, will support renewable energy, where Nepal has a massive potential."

Ambassador Lorenzo presented the highlights of the year-long celebrations, including the Nepal European Union Film Festival (NEUFF) – beginning on March 20, Europe Day, on May 9, the EU-Nepal Business Forum and Fair, on May 15 and 16, a Photo Competition - and its exhibition in August, as well as the Erasmus Road Show – throughout September in all seven provinces of Nepal, and culminating with the 'Study in Europe' Fair.

Pra-kriti: Pratisthapan Art Exhibition on display



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

The 'Pra-kriti: Pratisthapan Art Exhibition' began in collaboration between the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts and M Cube Gallery at the gallery of the academy on Thursday.

The exhibition was inaugurated by Jhapta Bahadur Saud, the Social Development Minister of Sudurpashchim Province.

The artworks of artists Sagar Manandhar, Sushila Singh, Mina Kayastha, Binay Rimal and Sushant Shree Rajbhandari were put on display.

Member Secretary of the Academy Devendra Kumar Kafle 'Thumkeli', highlighted the significance of the exhibition, particularly emphasising the importance of substitute art.

Saurganga Darshandhari, the council member of the academy, said that the exhibition of the created art would be held from February 15 to March 16 with a special emphasis on reconnecting with nature's essence.

She said that the art exhibition aimed to demonstrate the interdependent relationship between nature and humanity.

Minister Jhapta Bahadur Saud expressed his appreciation as an art enthusiast, noting that this was his first encounter with such art.

He lamented the ongoing conflict between nature and humanity, citing instances of human-induced environmental destruction and subsequent natural disasters.

Minister Saud expressed optimism about promoting artistic endeavours in Sudurpashchim Province, emphasising its rich artistic heritage.

Chancellor Naradamani Hartmchhali described substitution art as a medium for conveying various emotions through diverse media.

He praised the artists' adept portrayal of the relationship with nature through the utilisation of natural elements.

Hartmchhali suggested that contemporary issues such as social oppression should be addressed through art, as artists possess the ability to imbue ordinary objects with profound meaning and significance.

Matihani women learning Mithila painting



BY NAGENDRA KUMAR KARNA
Mahottari, Feb. 15

Hina Khatun of Ward No. 7 of Matihani Municipality is currently busy attending Mithila Painting training sessions in Matihani.

Despite belonging to a different religion and culture, she has been drawn to Mithila painting due to its reputation as a valuable skill.

Hina, an 11 grader at Ram Secondary School in Matihani, said that skills are not confined to any particular group based on religion, community, or culture. She expressed her interest in learning Mithila painting as a means to achieve independence.

Similarly, Nasima Khatun, of Ward No. 6 of the same municipality, has begun attending Mithila painting classes after completing her household chores. She diligently takes notes of the painting techniques shared by the instructor.

A total of 30 women from various communities, including Dalits and Muslims, have joined the Mithila painting training programme organised by the Community Learning Centre in Matihani-7, with the support of Matihani Municipality.

Shyam Kumar Mandal, President of the Community Learning Centre, said that the Mithila painting training aims to preserve cultural heritage and empower women with income-generating skills.

He said that the 35-day training programme would enable women to acquire valuable skills for self-sufficiency.

Manju Devi Sah, Deputy Mayor of Matihani Municipality, emphasised the high demand for Mithila painting in national and international markets.

She encouraged women to embrace this skill for earning income from home and become independent financially.

Following the training, the municipality pledges full support to further develop the women's skills and urges them to apply what they have learned.

Coach Menka Jha emphasised the recognition and respect that women gain through Mithila painting, which is deeply intertwined with Mithila's identity and heritage.

Chandeshwar Sah, the education coordinator of Matihani Municipality, lauded the Mithila painting training as a positive step in preserving Mithila's cultural arts amidst their gradual disappearance.

Dutmati Mundan Fair held by shaving heads of Danuwar kids

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Feb. 15



A one-day Dutmati Mundan Fair organised by Danuwar community has concluded at Mahendranagar in the Dhanusha district.

Every year, on the day of Shree Panachami, the community organises Dudhmati Mundan Fair.

In this festival, the people of Danuwar community shave the heads of their children and offer their hair in the Dudhamati Temple.

Manoj Singh Danuwar, a local, said that it is customary to shave the head of the children of Danuwar community in the temple located here in memory of the ancestors.

Shaving children's heads at the temple has been in practice for centuries, he said, adding that people of the Danuwar community bring their children to shave heads and offer hair to the temple.

"NO matter where they live, this is the single place where the Danuwar community people first shaves their head," he said. Hundreds of people come here on the day of Basnata Panchami to shave heads of their kids.

Surti Kumari Sah, Minister for Sports and Social Welfare of Madhes Province, said that the Danuwar community should not forget their tradition, identity, art and culture.

Stating that art, culture and costumes of all castes are the identity and jewel of the country, he expressed concern over the disappearance of Nepal's original culture due to the penetration of foreign culture.

Sean Wang and his grandmothers going to Oscars



AP
New York, Feb. 15

Sean Wang's two grandmothers live together. They read the newspaper together. They dance together. They sleep in the same bed and complain about each other's farts. The older of the two, Yi Yan Fuei, is 96. The younger, Chang Li Hua, is 86. They're in-laws but they act more like sisters.

When Wang, their 29-year-old grandson, was getting into filmmaking, one of the first he made was a short where Yi and Chang feed him blueberries. When Sean refuses, they kill him and bury him in the backyard.

Wang kept shooting them in their Bay Area home, especially after he moved back in with his nearby mum during the pandemic. They got accustomed to his camera being around. But they never thought it would lead to the Academy Awards.

"Wài Pó and Nǎi Nai," Wang's deeply charming portrait of his grandmothers, is nominated for best documentary short at the Academy Awards. In it, Wang films Yi and Chang going about their daily lives with bits of playfulness mixed in. They arm wrestle. They play dress-up. They watch "Superbad." But mostly, "Wài Pó and Nǎi Nai," which translates as maternal grandmother and paternal grandmother in Mandarin, captures the joy of two spirited ladies in older age as they occasionally chide their grandson's attempts to turn them into movie stars.

"When you first asked us to be movie stars, we were like, 'This must be a joke,'" Chang says in an interview by Zoom alongside Yi, with Wang joining from Los Angeles. "But now that we made this movie and it's going to the Oscars, we do kind of feel like movie stars. Now that this whole experience has happened, we do feel a little prettier."

When Oscar nominations were announced last month, it wasn't Bradley Cooper's or Emma Stone's reactions that went viral. It was the celebration, caught on video, of Yi and Chang, with Wang, his mum and producer Sam Davis standing over them.

In the film, which is streaming on Disney+, Yi and Chang reflect on mortality and the essential things in life. "As long as I have the newspaper, I can live," says Yi in the film, with magnifying glass in hand. Now, they're in the news, themselves.

"Every day I open the newspaper and if I got to see you, that'd be amazing," Yi tells Wang, who, after translating, shrugged: "I don't think we've made it into the Taiwanese newspapers yet."

A prominent news story a few years ago partly inspired Wang to make the movie. During the pandemic, when Asian and Asian-American hate crimes were escalating, he saw his grandmothers as a perfect antidote to the hateful stereotyping that followed COVID-19. At the same time, the short, which premiered last year at SXSW, was meant to essentially just be a simple home movie.

HOROSCOPE

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ARIES: Advice that you receive from your friends regarding a personal problem could be genuinely helpful at this time. That said, perhaps you were really hoping to sort things out all by yourself.

TAURUS: The world may finally start to understand what you've been up to lately. Perhaps you've recently made some choices that were a little disruptive. After good-natured Venus shifts into your 10th House of Reputation.

GEMINI: You can find the fun in learning even more than usual, Gemini. As passionate Venus slides into your intellectual 9th house, identifying a subject that you want to know more about could be downright delightful.

CANCER: Figuring out a comfortable way to share with others can currently be rewarding. While abundant Venus inhabits your 8th House of Joint Resources starting today.

LEO: Freshening the atmosphere of one of your close relationships is possible at this time. While busy Mercury in your partnership zone goads independent Uranus in your 10th House of Goals.

VIRGO: The most important part of your current drive to get things done might involve knowing when to take a break. As aesthetic Venus slips into your productive 6th house.

LIBRA: Following whatever you naturally find interesting can go well for you now. When relaxed Venus glides into your 5th House of Pleasure, you shouldn't have to agonize over how to entertain yourself.

SCORPIO: You may currently be inspired to make your home more beautiful. As creative Mercury in your domestic 4th house provokes innovative Uranus in your partnership zone.

SAGITTARIUS: Talking to people in a friendly way can make your life easier now. As amiable Venus pokes into your communication zone, you may realize the value of thinking before you speak.

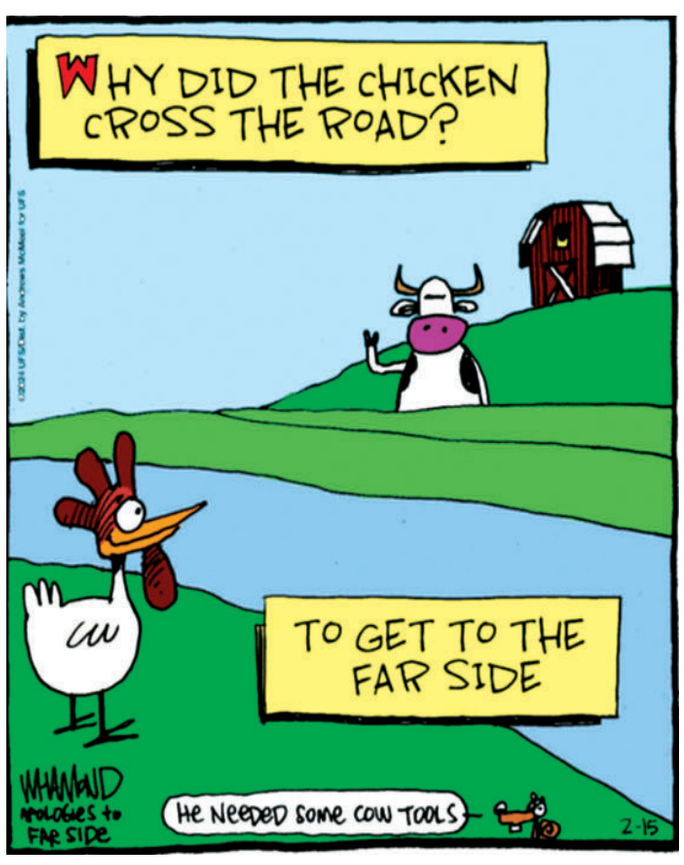
CAPRICORN: A little extra cash could be burning a hole in your pocket at the moment. Starting today, luxurious Venus pumps up your 2nd House of Resources.

AQUARIUS: The way you present yourself to the world could change for the better now. As favorable Venus bursts into your sign, you have a golden opportunity to update both your appearance and attitude.

PISCES: Your intuition could be heightened at the moment. When perceptive Mercury in your psychic 12th house produces sparks with volatile Uranus in your 3rd House of Thought.

CARTOON

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Eagles soar high ending Nepal's winning streak in home ODIs

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 15

Taking over the responsibility of the head coach on February 6, Monty Desai led the team for the first time in a tri-series of League 2 (2019-23) against Namibia and Scotland at the TU International Cricket Ground. Defeating Namibia in the first match of the series on February 14, 2023, Nepal won all six matches and whitewashed the tournament.

Desai's team, since then, had been unbeaten in home ODIs. The streak of Nepal under Desai ended after 13 matches at Kirtipur bastion as it lost to Namibia by four wickets in the inaugural match of the second edition of CWC League 2 (2024-27) on Thursday.

It is, however, Nepal's 15-match winning streak at TU Cricket Ground that was put on a brake by the African nation.

Before Desai's arrival, Nepal played a bilateral series against the United Arab Emirates (UAE) in November 2022 at Kirtipur. The Rhinos lost the first match to the UAE then and won two consecutive matches to claim the series 2-1.

With the 3-0 whitewash over Canada in the recent bilateral series, Nepal extended its run to 15 ODIs along with two List A internationals. It is the fourth-longest home winning streak in men's ODIs.

The confidence of Nepal in the home ground after a recent series clean sweep against Canada was destroyed by the Richelieu Eagles as they bundled out Nepal to their lowest-ever ODI total at Kirtipur and chased it with much ease.

The defeat was a wakeup call for Nepal according to skipper Rohit Paudel. He conceded that batters did not deliver as per expectation. "We have a decent bowling but failed in the batting department. The top-order batters disappointed us with their impatience today. The opponent bowlers perfectly utilized the tricky pitch condition. Our batters were unable to read the pitch and bat accordingly. We will be amending our mistakes in the next match."



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

Namibian cricketers celebrates after taking the wicket of Nepal's captain Rohit Paudel (unseen) during the opening match of second edition of ICC CWC League 2 at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Thursday.

Winning the toss, Namibia's captain Gerhard Erasmus elected to field first. Sending opener Kushal Bhurtel back to the dugout in the very first ball, Namibia declared that it was there with proper preparations.

Keeping the slips in place and bowling the first ball of the inning, Bhurtel was caught for an edge in the delivery by Ruben Trumpelmann while trying to drive the ball towards the off-side.

Before the first powerplay ended, Nepal had lost its top-four batsmen. Trumplemann took his second wicket of the match in the 3rd over as Anil Kumar Sah was struck leg before.

Showing his quality in the U19 team, Namibia called Jack Brassell to wear the senior team jersey and debut against Nepal. He took two major wickets for the Eagles as Aasif Sheikh (4 off 11) and captain Rohit Kumar Paudel (1 off 13) became his victims.

From 21/4 in 9.3 overs, Bhim Sharki and Kushal Malla started a steady partnership, but it broke in the 20th over. Malla (15 off 22) departed after getting caught by Tangeni Lungameni in the ball of the Namibian skipper.

Erasmus, who was adjudged the player of the match, went on to take his career-best five-wicket haul and restrict Nepal to 132 runs in 41.1 overs. Moreover, Erasmus implemented different plans on the field to claim the wickets of Nepali batsmen.

Erasmus, who bowled several deliveries from behind the stumps, was able to bamboozle Nepali batsmen on multiple occasions. Sompal Kami (2 off 6), Bhim Sharki (44 off 86), Gulshan Jha (21 off 31) and Karan KC (16 off 38) were the other wickets for Erasmus.

Jan Nicol Loftie-Eaton also opened his account as Pawan Sarraf (12 off 22) was caught by Erasmus in the 36th over. Meanwhile, in his three-over spell, Loftie-Eaton bowled two maiden overs and gave only five runs.

Doing his job with the ball when sought for, Loftie-Eaton hammered Namibia to the win with the bat. Namibia was able to chase the target in 33.1 overs losing six wickets.

Loftie-Eaton, who fell as the sixth wicket, departed adding 31 off 30 runs with five fours. He entered when Namibia was at 84/5 and departed leaving the team at 126/6.

Jan Frylinck (34 off 53) was Namibia's highest scorer. Opening duo Michael van Lingen and Nikolaas Davin added 23 and 15 runs respectively. JJ Smit (17 off 35) was the only other Namibian batsman to score in double figures.

While Nepal used seven bowlers to defend the target, Sompal Kami bagged three wickets in his seven-over spell while Lalit Narayan Rajbanshi and Rohit claimed two and one wickets respectively.

With Nepal facing the Netherlands on Saturday, the second match with the Eagles will take place on February 21.



Centuries by Sharma, Jadeja help India reach 326

AP
Rajkot, Feb. 15

Centuries by Rohit Sharma and Ravindra Jadeja underpinned India reaching 326-5 against England on day one Thursday of the third test.

India was 33-3 but Sharma and Jadeja rebuilt the innings with a 204-run stand. Sarfaraz Khan equalled the record for the fastest India half-century on test debut, 50 off 48. He was eventually run out for 62 just before stumps.

Jadeja was unbeaten on 110 and Sharma opened with 131.

England pacer Mark Wood took 3-69 from 17 overs.

Sharma and Jadeja played out the first wicketless session of the series in the afternoon. Jadeja reached 50 off 97 balls, and the two batters brought up 150 runs together. India went to tea at 185-3, then Sharma brought up his 11th test hundred off 157 balls.

The skipper opened up a bit more to hit three sixes and looked set for more but faced a short ball barrage from Wood after tea. Sharma mishit one Wood delivery straight to counterpart Ben Stokes at midwicket and was out within the first hour after tea.

That brought to the crease Khan, who belied his maiden test appearance by smashing the bowlers. Khan hit seven fours and a six, and a quick-fire 50 off 70 balls with Jadeja.

Khan was intent to race to three figures but his stay was cut short in a mixup with Jadeja, who was on 99 not out. He hit straight to mid-on, changed his mind about a single, but Khan was too far out of the non-striken's end and Wood hit the stumps directly.

Khan added 77 off 110 balls with Jadeja for the fifth wicket.

The left-handed allrounder Jadeja registered his fourth test hundred off 198 balls, but didn't celebrate with much enthusiasm.

It was his second test hundred at his home ground Rajkot, where he has two first-class triple hundreds and averages 142.18 with the bat.

Jadeja also became the third India allrounder to record 3,000 runs and 200 wickets in test cricket after Kapil Dev and Ravichandran Ashwin.

Earlier, Sharma and Jadeja helped India reach 93-3 at lunch.

India was reduced to 33-3 within nine overs after winning the toss.

Wood removed in-form batters Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill in the space of six deliveries.

Jaiswal, who scored a maiden double hundred in the second test, was caught at slip for 10 in the fourth over. Gill, who also scored a century in the previous test, was caught behind for a nine-ball duck.

SNIPPETS

Raju to judge in US Open Taekwondo

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepali international judge Raju Chhetri will be participating as a jury in the US Open Taekwondo 2024 in Reno, USA. The tourney is a world-ranking G-2 event organized by World Taekwondo and USA Taekwondo in partnership with the USA Olympic Committee. The tournament will start on Friday and will run for three days, with over 2,140 players, including Olympians and world champions, expected to participate.

Chhetri has previously acted as a judge in the World Ranking 9 G-10 Kim Yong Cup held in South Korea, the 2023 US Open World Ranking G-2 in Las Vegas, and the 2023 Seongnam Open in South Korea. Besides being a renowned judge, Chhetri is also the former president of NRNA South Korea and a gold medalist of the Korea Open World Ranking G-2 International Tournament 2008.

Sudurpaschim wins U19 T20 title

Nepalgunj (TRN): Sudurpaschim Province emerged as the champions of the Sushil Koirala Memorial Women's Under-19 National T20 Tournament on Thursday, after defeating Kohlpur Mayor-11 by two wickets in the final of the tournament which was organized by Kohlpur Municipality of Banke.

The final match was held at Kohlpur Cricket Stadium where Sudurpaschim successfully chased down the target of 103 runs given by Kohlpur Mayor-11 with the loss of 8 wickets in the last ball of the match. Hisila Khadka hit a four on the last ball when 1 run was needed, giving Sudurpaschim a thrilling victory. Sana Pravin, the captain of Kohlpur Mayor-11, was adjudged the best player of the tournament and also named the best batter.

The best bowler title was awarded to Rachna Chaudhary of Gandaki Pradesh. Similarly, Sabitri Dhami of Sudurpaschim was declared as the emerging talent of the tournament.

PSG edge closer to Champions League quarter-finals

AFP
Paris, Feb. 15

Kylian Mbappe scored the opener as Paris Saint-Germain took a big step towards reaching the Champions League quarter-finals with a 2-0 win over Real Sociedad in the first leg of their last-16 tie on Wednesday.

The mediocrity of PSG's first-half performance at the Parc des Princes may have had their supporters fearing another in a long line of disappointing results down the years in the Champions League knockout stages.

But Mbappe, who is expected to leave the club at the end of the season when his contract expires, broke the deadlock from close range just before the hour mark.

Bradley Barcola's well-taken goal in the 70th minute then made it 2-0 to give the French champions a comfortable cushion to take to Spain for the return early next month.

"We managed to score at key moments. We are happy with this first step. There is still a lot of work to do but it is good to be going there with the advantage," Mbappe told broadcaster Canal Plus.

Captain Marquinhos added: "We were in great difficulty in the first half but we knew that would be the case. "The coach gave us an earbashing at half-time and I think that helped because the attitude was much better in the second half.

"We know how important it is to win at home but it is not finished. We need to keep the same mindset between now and then, keep playing well in the league and then go there and play well to secure our qualification."

There was big pressure on PSG coming into this tie after they had gone out in the last 16 of the Champions League in five of the last seven seasons. Another early exit this season would be a monumental setback for the Qatar-owned club, especially as Real Sociedad were appearing in their first Champions League knockout tie in two decades.

They now have something of a mountain to climb when they entertain PSG in San Sebastian on March 5, although supporters of the French side will remain wary given the way they have collapsed at this stage of the competition in recent years against Barcelona and Madrid, among others.

Immobile hands Lazio advantage

Ciro Immobile fired Lazio towards a first Champions League quarter-final in nearly a quarter of a century in Wednesday's 1-0 win over Bayern Munich which plunged their troubled opponents even deeper into crisis.

Italy forward Immobile slotted home the last 16, first leg's decisive goal from the penalty spot in the 69th minute in Rome to pile pressure on Bundesliga champions Bayern, who risk having a disastrous season by their own exalted standards.

The spot-kick was won by Gustav Isaksen who was clattered by Dayot Upamecano with a rash tackle which earned the France defender a red card and left Bayern a man down for the final 20 minutes.

Immobile's strike came days after he netted his 200th Serie A goal and allowed a raucous Lazio home crowd to dream of a first quarter-final in Europe's top competition in 24 years.

"We prepared for this match so that we could give Bayern a game. Even if we'd only had a 10 percent chance the team would have given everything on the pitch," said Ciro Immobile to Amazon Prime Video.

"We wanted to give our supporters a good night and I think we've done that."

However Bayern are a club in a slump and a toothless display in the Italian capital in which they didn't have a single shot on target will do nothing to help embattled coach Thomas Tuchel.



BEDINGHAM 'CONFIDENT' PROTEAS CAN LEVEL SERIES

AFP
Hamilton Feb. 15

South Africa's David Bedingham scored a maiden century on Thursday and then said he was "very confident" they could dismiss New Zealand short of the 267 needed to win the second and final Test in Hamilton.

New Zealand, inspired by debut seamer Will O'Rourke's five-wicket haul, were 40-1 in their second innings at stumps on day three, needing a 227 more to complete a record run chase and a 2-0 series win. Tom Latham was not out on 21 while Devon Conway was trapped leg before wicket by Dane Piedt for 17 in the day's final over.

The highest successful fourth-innings chase by any team at Seddon Park was 212, achieved by Australia against New Zealand 24 years ago.

Bedingham's career-high 110 was comfortably the standout knock in South Africa's second innings of 235, supported by 43 from Keegan Petersen and 34 from captain Neil Brand.

It handed the understrength tourists an opportunity to square the series and deny New Zealand their first-ever series win over the Proteas. "Our goal was to bat through the day so we were a bit short of that but I think taking Conway's wicket right at the end is a massive bonus," Bedingham said.

"Inside the changing room we have 11 guys who are very confident we can win it. I just hope my 110 is in a winning cause."

With his team 31 runs ahead on first innings, Bedingham batted aggressively in difficult conditions. The 29-year-old scored 12 fours and two sixes in a 141-ball stay that followed his 87 in the first Test in Mount Maunganui, which South Africa lost by 281 runs.

Bedingham and Petersen combined for a crucial fifth-wicket stand of 98 before Petersen's dismissal sparked a collapse, with the last six wickets falling for 33.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:41 am, Sunset at 5:55 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 20 - 22°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.8	6.9	0.0
Dadeldhura	18.7	5.5	0.0
Dhangadi	26.3	11.0	0.0
Birendranagar	25.1	7.6	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.2	11.8	0.0
Jumla	19.4	-2.7	0.0
Ghorahi	24.7	9.5	0.0
Pokhara	23.2	8.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	24.9	9.0	0.0
Simara	26.4	8.0	0.0
Kathmandu	22.2	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.4	8.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.4	8.0	0.0
Dhankuta	24.5	10.6	0.0
Biratnagar	26.7	12.0	0.0
Jomsom	14.1	-1.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.0	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	5.8	0.0*
Janakpur	29.0	13.5	0.0*
Jiri	17.0	2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 16, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.58	Rs. 133.18
Euro	1	Rs. 142.35	Rs. 143.00
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.35	Rs. 167.10
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.11	Rs. 150.79
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.15	Rs. 86.54
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 97.90	Rs. 98.35
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.38	Rs. 98.82
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.84	Rs. 8.88
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.36	Rs. 36.52
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.67	Rs. 3.68
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.73	Rs. 27.86
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.64	Rs. 12.70
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.10	Rs. 19.18
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.26	Rs. 432.21
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.68	Rs. 353.27

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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